Justice: There's No Making Right What's Gone

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34399450.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), All the canon ships

Characters:
Hordak (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Micah (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Post-Canon, Post-War, Fluff, Imperialism, Aftermath of Violence, Hurt/Comfort, Damaged People Being Damaged, Light dusting of crack, smattering of smut, Everyone Needs A Hug, [mild catradora smut ch2], [entrapdak smut ch4]

Language:
English

Series:
Part 3 of Season of the Survivor

Stats:
Published: 2021-10-10 Completed: 2021-10-20 Words: 28,036 Chapters: 5/5

Justice: There's No Making Right What's Gone

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34399450.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), All the canon ships

Characters:
Hordak (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Micah (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Post-Canon, Post-War, Fluff, Imperialism, Aftermath of Violence, Hurt/Comfort, Damaged People Being Damaged, Light dusting of crack, smattering of smut, Everyone Needs A Hug, [mild catradora smut ch2], [entrapdak smut ch4]

Language:
English

Series:
Part 3 of Season of the Survivor

Stats:

Published: 2021-10-10 Completed: 2021-10-20 Words: 28,036
Chapters: 5/5

Justice: There's No Making Right What's Gone

by AintGonnaHauntItself

Summary

Etheria needs justice, but the planet isn't just full of war victims, it's also full of war villains. Now they have to figure out how to share a future together, whether they like it or not. Meanwhile, the universe is watching.

Notes

This series is mostly from the POVs of Hordak and Catra, and loosely follows the development of their begrudging acceptance of one another and the way they face their rolls in Etheria's destruction. Definitely written from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the work for more notes

"None of us can outrun the violence we do to others.”

Chapter Summary

> The assembly begins to realize the extent of the mess they're in the middle of. Catra begins to understand the magnitude and scope of the consequences of her own actions (they are some CONSEQUENCES.) Hordak throws gasoline on the brush fire, because of course he does. The princesses observe the unfolding shit show with vague consternation.

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I want everyone here to be very clear on the decisions that will be made here today.”

“Explain,” the queen commanded simply.

This was his chance. He needed to make his case concisely, and he tried to select his words carefully despite the spell. “No matter what you do, the people of Etheria will continue to suffer." Princess Mermista rolled her eyes and many of the people in his immediate vision exchanged raised eyebrows. "The global devastation has affected every single Etherian without exception." Princess Frosta crossed her arms and Perfuma scowled. "Your infrastructure is devastated, and I doubt the release of Etheria’s magic has done anything but damage it further. Wartime inflation will almost certainly continue, and poverty will be more widespread than can be absorbed or responded to easily. The

economy has been completely destroyed and in unfamiliar terrain of every kind, it will be years before a new market can be stabilized." Princesses Netossa, Spinnerella, and Micah exchange worried glances. Catra placed her head between her hands as she continued to stare at him intently. Adora rubbed her back lightly for a moment, but soon gave up and returned her attention to him.

Princess Mermista seemed more shaken than bored now as she glared at him as well. He returned her gaze coolly and hoped she was listening. "Countless civilians are searching for lost loved ones as we speak and all communication systems and means of travel have been mangled beyond recognition. The scale of destruction and upheaval will gradually become more apparent to the people as will their disillusionment with the assumptions they made about life after victory." He wondered briefly if the princesses would be able to keep their people faithful and trusting. Hopefully the clones would at least be patient and helpful, so long as the princesses could keep them safe. "Food distribution, petty crime, and morale will be problems in every kingdom on Etheria. Perhaps most difficult of all will be the task of coming to grips with the complete and utter disruption of the Etherian way of life. All former patterns Etheria's social fabrics are gone. The general chaos and loss of context will be bewildering and devastating."

"Okay, I feel like you're being really negative right now," Princess Perfuma sounded and looked slightly frantic, "and you're counting on the worst-case scenarios here. We shouldn't be asking 'what if-' we should be…"

"No, he's right." This time it was Lance, who looked somberly back at Hordak. "Those are just postwar realities, Perfuma. Etheria is plentiful, we're going to handle it, and we're going to be okay, but everything he said will be a problem that we need to prepare for."

Princess Mermista's face crumpled before she pressed her hands over it, and everyone else in the room seemed to be grappling with the reality-check. The queen, however, pressed on with an

exhausted sigh. “Why are you saying all of this at your trial? Or, hearing or whatever. Meeting.”

He paused for a moment before answering to make sure they were listening. He cleared his throat before saying clearly and firmly, “to make the point that the people of Etheria need to see a display of justice.” Several heads snapped up as people looked at him in confusion. “After Prime’s assault, practically every person on this planet is a victim of the war I waged, directly or indirectly. My motives and any extenuating circumstances are completely irrelevant considering the inescapable reality of the damage I caused. Furthermore, war victims have every right to hate whichever responsible military for committing the unforgivable." He allowed himself to huff in bitterness. "Unconditional rejection is the only appropriate reaction to have toward savagery, after all." Both Catra and Wrong Hordak cocked their heads, but theirs was the only overt reaction. "This level of devastation, however, makes individual justice impossible.” He paused and looked around, making sure that the princesses were following him. “To keep this unrequited suffering- this need for justice- from turning into civil conflict later on, *the people need to see a visible, meaningful, material gesture of serving justice.* I cannot overemphasize that unrequited suffering is one of the easiest social issues for *anyone* to manipulate to their advantage.” He spoke the next words slowly and clearly. “If you do not provide your people with a villain upon whom to affix their pain, somebody will.” He paused again then, trying to figure out if they were on the same page, yet.

“Continue,” the Queen prompted.

Hordak obliged. “If another party other than yourselves gives your people their villain, they will have offered a more complete narrative than you. Once their version of things is established, it is extremely difficult to undo. For the sake of maintaining control of the narrative, you need to have a villain in place. Recall, for example, that by abusing this social mechanism, I kept the Etherian Horde loyal and devoted." Catra, Scorpia, and Adora exchanged glances. "I convinced them that the princesses were the reason for all their problems, and the hatred and fear came

naturally. I used it to keep them fighting, but I've used the same tactic to divide and terminate inconvenient resistance before." He shifted his weight in his seat as his hurt arm transitioned from aching to burning. He was so very, very tired. "I suggest you do the same here, before anybody else steps in to take advantage of the chaos." There was far less of a reaction than he'd expected and he worried that he wasn't effectively conveying the gravity of their situation.

"But, we do have a villain," Adora said uncertainly, "Prime was the villain. And the bad guy got what was coming, and we can all move on… right?"

"That may be enough for refugee clones, but remember that your communities will also be absorbing previous members of the Etherian Horde; Etherians who fought against their own people and paved the way for Prime. Such a wound won't be easy to balm with the defeat of Prime and his hivemind. You need to hold somebody responsible for what was done before anyone was chipped. The people won't understand if you chose to get rid of one tyrant but keep the other."

"What do you mean?" It was Princess Scorpia who asked, and she looked especially upset in a room full of distressed people.

He thought he heard Entrapta fidget in her seat behind him and thought she must be getting very antsy after so much time sitting still. "I mean," he took a deep breath through the burning pain along his left side and stole himself, "I will peacefully and willingly accept the role, in return for a promise in writing that no other previous members of the Etherian Horde, nor their collaborators, are to be punished for the military actions they participated in while under my command."

"And what kind of justice do you suggest we serve the people?" King Micah asked, eyes narrowed.

It was another direct question. "Personally, I would suggest public execution."

This time there was definitely a significant reaction all around the room. Entrapta gave an odd kind of squawk of alarm behind him and Princess Mermista loudly drawled "Okay, wow. Dramatic much?"

Catra, who'd slapped her palm to her forehead, grunted, "Hordak is the most dramatic fucking person on Etheria."

"Alright, alright," the Queen called, "calm down everybody." She gave the room a few seconds to settle before addressing Hordak. "I know you come from a messed-up place, but this is Etheria. We don't do executions here, let alone public ones. We're the good guys, remember?"

Hordak arched his brow at her. "Princess Entrapta intimated as much, but I assumed that given the circumstances…"

"Do you *want* to be punished?" King Micah asked.

Hordak thought it might have been a facetious question, but he was compelled to answer anyway. "What I *want* is a future in which Entrapta can live her life in peace and plenty," he growled through his teeth. "But that's not going to happen if you don't placate my victims."

"'Kay, you're really bumming me out here. Can we get on with this?" Princess Mermista interrupted. Nobody seemed to know what to say. As the seconds slid by the tension in the room rose. Mermista made a frustrated sound and shifted in her seat. "So what, he's just going to dictate what we do here?"

"No," Adora said firmly. Hordak looked up at her in confusion. "That's not how this works." Adora fixed him with a stern glare. "Hordak, you're not Prime. I destroyed him by flooding you and the hivemind with Etherian magic. If you were truly evil, you wouldn't have walked away from that unscathed."

"I know that I was and am more than what he made me," Hordak insisted, trying to keep his tone measured and calm. "That is precisely the problem. What I chose to do with my own free

will...” He sighed and screwed up his face, closing his eyes against his own truth. He took a few calming breaths before continuing. “I do not suggest that I have only ever done evil in my life. I am pointing out that it ultimately does not matter. It's too late to put right what I've done. The only people...” he began, but he had to swallow drily and try again. “The only people that have the right to forgive me are dead.”

“Okay everybody, moving right along,” Princess Mermista grunted, wiping at her own eyes. Again and again she tried to steer the meeting back on track and she was beginning to look tired. “I, too, am freaking shocked to hear Hordak acting sorry for anything.” Hordak didn’t understand the surprise. After all, he’d spent who knew how long apologizing at Prime’s feet, begging for mercy and prostrating himself in denunciation of his failures. “But the entire point of this hearing was to decide what to do with him. So... what do we do with him?”

King Micah spoke up, stroking his beard. “Exile? He’d probably be fine on Beast Island. He’s tough.”

“No offense your highness,” the archer Bow broke in, “but the ex-evil, zealot, fascist dictator also happens to be kind of a mad scientist. And I feel like maybe we should keep the mad scientist under really close supervision instead of sending him to an island full of dangerous technology.”

The king huffed in begrudging agreement.

“How about, like, permanent community service?” the queen suggested. “Like an indefinite sentence where he helps rebuild Etheria until we decide to release him?”

“After everything he told us earlier,” Princess Mermista argued, “and after everything he did to our people, are we seriously just going to sentence him to community service? I get that we’re the good guys, but shouldn’t the punishment fit the crime a little more?”

Catra heaved a sigh and switched ridiculous positions in her chair, clearly readying to speak. “I know you don’t want to hear this, but we should also remember that Prime *already* punished Hordak for what he did on Etheria.” She shifted again, looking uncomfortable. Hordak’s hearts began to pound again and his throat constricted.

“What kind of punishment?” Princess Mermista asked, and although she was still scowling, the question sounded more curious than vindictive. Catra clenched her jaw and her tail flicked in apparent agitation. After another couple of seconds of starting into the beginnings of words, she crossed her arms protectively over her chest and still didn’t speak.

“When they dragged him away, Prime told them to take Hordak for… reconditioning?” Queen Glimmer prompted.

Catra snorted bitterly and she narrowed her eyes at the table in front of her. “He calls… *called* it reconditioning, but the point is to replace what *used* to be a person with another copy of himself. First he makes sure you know he’s in charge, whatever it takes for you to stop fighting him.” She shrugged tightly. “When Prime decided someone was his... I mean, he'd been alive for untold ages and seen the universe." She swallowed hard and her eyes grew overbright. "The guy knew how to break a person down to nothing.” Hordak could see her begin to tremble and was grateful to her for keeping things vague. He broke out into a cold sweat himself. “Then he waltzes into your head and uses your memories to do what he wants to you, then he takes them away from you along with your identity. Meanwhile he uses pain to make you play your part.” Her eyes had gone flat now and when a concerned Adora grabbed her hand, it remained limp. “It’s really not that fancy. Just his own brand of torture.”

Hordak heard Entrapta suck in quiet, shuddering breath and he looked over in time to see what must have been a tear drop from beneath her mask. “That’s enough, Catra,” he said, trying to slow his breathing as it picked up again.

"See, but that's the thing, it *wasn't* enough. Your memories were stubborn, weren't they?" Catra brought Hordak's attention snapping back to her and she lifted her gaze to meet his. As they made eye contact, he knew she could sense his dread. She narrowed her eyes and cocked her head, picking apart his reactions. She'd always been too intuitive for her own good. "How long did he work on you before he was satisfied? How long did that first round take?"

It was a direct question, so he had to answer. "I. Can't. Remember," he ground out through clenched teeth. A ripple of murmuring and disturbed glances spread around the room. He saw Entrapta pull her fists in tighter against herself from the corner of his eye. Adora looked upset and was holding Catra's hand with both her own, leaning forward and gazing into her face with a pained expression. Even Princess Mermista looked unsettled.

"First round?" Queen Glimmer asked, looking slightly nauseous.

Catra snorted again and broke their eye contact as he willed her to stop talking. "Like I said, his memories were stubborn. At some point I recognized him because he knew my name, but I don't think he could remember why. I called him Hordak." She pulled her hand from Adora's so as to rub the back of her neck. "I guess it was a bad feeling for him, because he went to Prime and confessed, begging forgiveness." Several princesses exchanged surprised glances. "Later on, Prime was trying to get me to help him lure Adora into a trap and he was… he was threatening me, I guess. He had me watch Hordak's re-purification ritual. He wanted me to see what I had coming." Her eyes welled and unfocused, and he could tell she was seeing it all again, playing overtop of their present reality like an incongruous hologram. He was watching it all over again, too. "Hordak went to Prime and asked for him to take his memories away. He *actually* asked for more." She paused while people processed her words and she kept avoiding his eyes. He imagined she must be struggling against the memories of her own reconditioning and purification. When she spoke again, she flicked her gaze up to his for a moment as she

addressed him directly. “You looked at me, and you were scared. Prime made me watch while a hundred or so clones surrounded us, chanting, and... and *wailing* , and then you…” She swallowed thickly and Hordak’s hearts pounded in his chest. “I really, really wish I could forget the way you screamed.”

A loud snapping sound startled almost everyone in the room. Hordak looked around for the source of the noise until he realized that he’d accidentally punched his fingers through the lacquered finish on the table, embedding them into the wood beneath. He pulled his hands free and looked around himself. “Apologies,” he muttered. He couldn’t bear to look at Entrapta, who hadn’t moved at all. He could merely hear her shallow breathing.

“I… I’m sorry, I…” Catra said to no one as she roused herself. “I’m just trying to say… there’s no point in trying to out-punish Prime when it comes to Hordak.” She huffed and squared her shoulders. “I need a break,” she said before hurriedly leaving the room, Adora on her heels.

“Oh man,” the archer murmured to himself, somewhat mournfully, putting a hand to the back of his head to rub the fuzz there.

Queen Glimmer heaved a huge sigh and shook her head, trying to rouse herself as well. “I think we could all use a break,” she said with a brittle voice.

“Please,” Hordak said softly as he felt his heartrates begin to slow again. The room of people looked around at him. “Please… can we just get this over with?”

After a moment Queen Glimmer acquiesced. “Very Well.” She heaved another sigh and blew it out slowly. “Alright. Moving forward.” She seemed to struggle to collect her thoughts.

“May I speak?” Hordak asked.

Catra and Adora quietly returned before Queen Glimmer replied. “Yeah just, keep on track.”

He began to argue his case again. “Peace without justice isn’t sustainable, and the public’s suffering needs to be publicly addressed and acted upon by their leaders. In addition, you can use my punishment to redirect blame from my troops, who acted in my name, and help ease their transition into Etherian society." He needed Etherians to welcome Entrapta back. She had helped him to hurt them, and now he needed them to be able to forgive her. "Etherians are emotional beings, and unrequited pain will fester in their minds and create trouble eventually.”

"Hordak," Perfuma said gently, "you really have no faith in the people, do you?"

Swift Wind laughed derisively. "The people in power are usually like that. They've forgotten how to survive, so when the going gets tough, they assume poor people will panic like they do."

Hordak opened his mouth for rebuttal, but Perfuma didn't let him argue. "Okay, well, stop assuming the worst of postwar chaos and give the people a chance to prove what they're capable of," she scolded, before shifting her tone warmer. "I think you'll be surprised."

They were still fighting it. Somehow, even after Prime, they were still willing to gamble for their fantasies. They were more like Entrapta than he'd ever imagined or given them credit for, and he was more wretched for it. Even so, he took a moment to focus on his ears, willing them to stay up and assertive instead of lowering. He hadn't resorted to begging, yet. “A visible, substantial, and inclusive demonstration of justice of some kind is *absolutely* necessary. If your priority is to protect and serve the people, then you must remember that the entire point is to give the public a feeling that some sort of order is being made of this mess. Create a narrative in which peace can endure.”

“I really hate to agree with him again, but he’s got a point.” Lance made an apologetic face at the queen. “The pattern he’s telling us to avoid is common enough throughout history that it’s significant.”

“But that *still* leaves the question of what to do with him,” the queen replied, frustration in her tone.

Princess Mermista began to speak, though her head and shoulders were still lowered. “Honestly, this is as much about Entrapta as anything. She doesn’t want to leave you behind, and after everything she did to help save us all, nobody really wants to make her.” She gave Entrapta a pained look, but she still had her mask down and her fists together. Mermista continued, “Yesterday I went home and got a taste of what my people are *still* going through. By this morning, I was really, really angry all over again. On some level I’m still angry, but at this point…" She seemed to get lost in her thoughts for a moment, eyes growing most. "Now I’m mostly just sad. And tired. I’m tired of the destruction, I’m tired of all the waste, and even *I’m* not willing to continue what Prime started on Hordak.”

“No matter how bad we feel for him, our first priority *is* to serve our people,” Princess Netossa broke in, glancing at Hordak.

“Whatever you do, I urge you to maintain tight control of the narrative- no gaps or insufficiencies, because they *will* be filled and then used beyond what you can control.” Several people gave skeptical looks at one another, and he realized they assumed he was being overdramatic. Well, admittedly he was being a bit dramatic, but it was entirely warranted. “When I was with Prime," he pressed, "I saw that your story, the message of your rebellion, has already traveled far. Other worlds were inspired by your resistance and rose up against our forces in the name of the rebellion. In the name of She-Ra. Tales from Etheria are, as we speak, circulating throughout the empire.”

The princesses didn’t seem to know how to react. The pirate next to Princess Mermista began whispering to her excitedly and she rolled her eyes at whatever he was saying.

“In fact…” Damn. He hadn’t even thought of it until now. “You will need to send out envoys, and if not envoys, at least send out messages to the other planets in the empire, beginning with the

nearest. You need to establish as many positive relationships as possible; Etheria is new and inexperienced and technologically behind the rest of the known universe. You need all the allies you can muster. Even if responses are unfriendly, you would be better off with an idea of who to be wary of." Hordak spoke as earnestly as he could, desperate for them to understand the urgency of their situation. Etheria was in an extremely precarious position, not only among the peoples of their world, but among a freshly collapsed empire and a sudden and extreme power vacuum. Anxiety bubbled within him as he considered the planet's naked vulnerability. This time he could not keep his ears from lowering slightly. Catra and Adora both scowled.

Swift Wind cleared his throat and addressed the group for the first time since they'd started. "We need to be careful about whatever we end up doing. Like it or not, we're going to be scrutinized, criticized, analyzed, emulated, replicated, and overall, just a really big deal. We need to remember that however we go from here, it's probably going to represent who we are to the rest of the known universe." He was met with stunned silence and he made a sheepish face. "No pressure though."

"Okay," Queen Glimmer said. Hordak couldn't be sure, but he thought she might have broken out in a sweat. "Okay…"

"There there, everyone." Lance spoke again. "It's a big job but we're up to it."

"We took down Prime. I'm sure we can handle whatever comes our way," said Queen Glimmer. "There's a lot of us to meet the challenges ahead."

"If we need to control the narrative, then maybe building the narrative is something we should focus on," said Lance.

"Lance is right," said the other man with the mustache. "What we did here was amazing, so let's start collecting our truth. It'll help people sort out what they've been through, too."

“Thank you, George,” said Lance, nodding at the other. “I’m thinking we could -and maybe should- organize teams of anthropologists and ethnographers to start collecting stories from everybody who wants to tell theirs.”

“We can compile the information into an official report, which we can make available to anyone who wants to know,” suggested George.

“Nerds,” Catra muttered.

Princess Perfuma spoke up again. “How about memorials?” she asked, “The memorial we made for Entrapta when we thought she was dead seemed to make people feel better. It helped with survivor’s guilt, anyway.”

Horak felt some strange and unpleasant emotions at the idea of memorials to a dead Entrapta, but he didn’t have time to consider them before Bow cut in. “Community makers could team up with builders to memorialize all we’ve lost,” he suggested.

“Some of my people and I could join in and work on healing ceremonies,” Princess Perfuma offered, and Hordak couldn’t help but raise a skeptical brow. “That would create a space to get together and grieve and comfort one another. It might be a good way to help people learn some tools for processing things,” she said, giving Catra a meaningful look. Catra scowled and looked away, pointedly.

“Community representatives could do networking and help direct those teams to people who want to talk,” Swift Wind posed.

“Do these suggestions apply to disaffected clones?” Wrong Hordak asked hopefully.

“You know it, buddy,” Swift Wind exclaimed.

“Suffering,” Hordak interrupted. Both Catra and Mermista groaned, “can’t be reversed by a return to material normalcy alone. Nor can it be reversed by compassion, or technological

advancements, however welcome such things may be. It can only be actively countered by concrete social action that symbolizes the transition into a new and better world," he argued.

"Why couldn't we try to fill that need for social action with a visible life of service to Etheria?" asked Swift Wind.

"You guys are using really fancy words," Frosta complained.

"Yeah, you're losing me," Adora agreed.

"Hordak," this time it was Princess Perfuma who spoke, addressing him directly with a kind expression, "people are capable of seeing more than one victim or villain at a time. They're also capable of feeling sympathy in more than one direction, even if it seems contradictory." She ran her gaze around the room then. "Even though you hurt them like Prime hurt you, I don't think our people will want that cycle to go on any longer. We won. Magic won. *Friendship* won." She smiled at everyone around the room, positively gushing with idealism. "The beauty of variety and wildness and joy and regeneration won. Now we heal. Now we grow new life from the ashes of what we lost."

"And," George said to Hordak, "If you really are feeling some of what you've done, then you're going to be serving penance the rest of your life. None of us can outrun the violence we do to others." His words, unlike everybody else's yet that day, struck fear in Hordak's hearts. The other man's serious expression betrayed a hint of deepest sorrow, and the warmth of Lance's hand on his shoulder did not reach his eyes.

"Hordak," Adora spoke again. "I'm going to ask you a very important question." She fixed him with an electric blue glare that made his hair raise. "What do you want?"

Hordak shook his head, struggling to form a truth to speak. "I don't think I have enough of a person left inside of me to have wants," he finally said slowly.

“ *You are a person* .” He looked up and saw that it was the archer, Bow, who spoke so fiercely. “You are a whole person. You have always been and will always be a person.”

“Your sense of self has just been through the wringer is all,” Princess Perfuma said in her kind, gentle tone, “but with time that'll build back up again.”

They waited and listened while he struggled with his reply. “Then…” He thought hard. “Then I want peace. And I would consider any opportunity to participate in establishing and protecting peace to be the highest of honors, though certainly one that I do not deserve."

After a few moments of silence, Entrapta spoke up. “Hordak and I *could* make lots of tech to help with all of these various aspects of reconstruction. Also, he does have kind of a knack for creative civics.”

“Creative civics is a pleasant name for military dictatorship,” King Micah quipped.

Lance spoke again. “I know this is all really overwhelming, and I know it feels like we’re in uncharted territory, but you know, the future *always* has to be invented before it’s realized.”

“Every inch of progress ever made in history started out as far-fetched fantasy and wishful thinking,” George added.

“Speaking of narrative,” Adora broke in abruptly, speaking directly to Hordak, “how did you go from multiple-times brainwashed clone to channeling Prime on that cliff?”

Before he could answer, Princess Frosta interrupted. “Hang on, what’s the deal with that pink crystal you’ve had this whole time? You keep messing with it in your hand.”

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

“Fuckin’ Entrapta,”

Chapter Summary

> Hordak should probably give up on that whole 'dignity' thing, as far as the princesses are concerned. Catra survives the hearing along with everyone else. She and Double Trouble have a small chat.

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Hang on, what’s the deal with that pink crystal you’ve had this whole time? You keep messing with it in your hand.”

Hordak sighed. “It’s the piece of technology that powered the armor Entrapta built.” On second thought, he decided to lay it on the table to show that it wasn’t dangerous.

“I would like Bow to examine that,” Queen glimmer said, looking at the archer but nodding toward Hordak.

The archer stood up and walked awkwardly around the circle of tables, excusing himself and apologizing as he went. When he reached their table, Hordak forced himself to hand over Entrapta's crystal after the slightest hesitation. It was his only possession and he couldn't bear to lose it, but he trusted that Entrapta wouldn't let that happen. Bow returned to his seat just as awkwardly and examined the crystal for mere moments before passing it to the two men behind him. “Is that First One’s writing?” he asked.

Hordak wondered if it was. “Can I see it?” Adora asked after they’d looked it over. They passed it along.

Hordak looked at Entrapta, who had her mask down again and was fidgeting with her fingers. “Did you know the design was writing?” he asked her.

"I uh, I actually put it there," she answered in a startlingly meek tone. He looked back at Adora, who was still staring down at the crystal.

“What does it say, Adora?” asked Catra, who was watching her closely.

After another moment, Adora seemed to rouse herself and passed the crystal back. “Nothing. It’s First Ones’ letters but it’s not a full word, just pretty nonsense.”

“What does it say, Hordak?” Catra asked, eyes still locked on Adora, who was now staring intently at Entrapta.

“I had assumed it was decorative, I have no idea what it might say,” he answered truthfully.

“Why does that thing seem familiar?” Swift Wind asked, squinting as it was passed before him.

“I,” Hordak replied uncertainly, “I believe you might have seen it when I found Entrapta near one of the spires.”

A round of whispering swept the room as Swift Wind continued. “So that *was* you.”

Hordak nodded. “I had found the crystal on the Velvet Glove, and it made me remember…”

“You just… remembered?” Princess Mermista asked.

“No I mean, It brought back a few flashes of… memories… but that was all.” He managed to avoid admitting that all he’d

remembered was his most precious moments with Entrapta.

“But you kept it all that time?” Bow asked with a raised brow.

“I didn’t want to lose the feeling it gave me, even though I knew I was stepping into blasphemous territory." He snorted bitterly. "It seems I am a blasphemer, through and through." Hordak repressed a shudder as he continued carefully. "The crystal allowed me to start working at re-forging connections in my mind. It was… difficult,” he admitted, ashamed by how long it had taken.

“So that’s why you didn’t hurt her. You remembered her.” Swift Wind said, and Hordak nodded.

More and more people scrutinized him with growing interest, and several heads were turning between himself and Entrapta. “What a twist!” said the pirate in a high-pitched stage-whisper.

“Anyway,” the queen said, “I want you to answer Adora’s question. How did you go from brainwashed clone to channeling Prime on that battlefield?”

“After my reconditioning and purification, I assume he kept me on the Velvet Glove to maintain access to my memories of Etheria. He summoned me to his side yesterday morning to witness… I think he wanted me to watch the end. The end… the end of everything,” he said as his throat constricted slightly. “But then, he brought Entrapta there, and I was frightened, but I still couldn’t remember." He looked over at her. She was still facing ahead with her mask down, but she wasn't wringing her hands, at least. "She was so defiant. She wouldn’t stop telling him off- she refused to obey.” He allowed a small smile and registered that the room was not as quiet as before. Then his next words wiped his smile away and he scowled. “Then he told me to kill her.” His throat constricted suddenly, Entrapta shifted in her seat, and he took a moment to retrain his voice. “But I couldn’t.”

The murmuring grew louder around the room. “Alright, alright, calm down. I want to hear this,” Glimmer said, sounding annoyed. "Keep talking, Hordak."

“She started to cry and when he told me to kill her again,” he shut his eyes tight, too cowardly to face the crowd, “I still couldn’t do it.” He took a calming breath, eyes still closed. “It was the last push, somehow. I… I… *felt* myself wake up,” he shook his head at his own vague words, trying to understand what the spell was making him say. “I could remember that I had an *entire life* without him, so I turned and shot Prime instead. Then I threw him off the viewing platform into the void below.”

After a moment of shocked silence, the room broke out in the loudest round of conversation yet. “I thought She-Ra killed Prime!” Princess Frosta shouted above the commotion.

The room quieted quickly enough for what Adora said to be clear. “No,” she said slowly, squinting at Hordak, “I didn’t. I burned him out of the Hive Mind, but he didn’t have a body to take refuge in.” As the murmuring started back up again, her expression softened. “Hordak killed Prime. I didn’t have to. Thank you for that, Hordak.”

Hordak was already shaking his head in response. "It did not matter. The action was utterly useless. I did not keep him from harming Entrapta as easily as ever, and I did nothing to combat his assault on the heart."

Entrapta shifted again and faces around the room looked confused, unsure of what to think or how to react. Catra spoke clearly over the low noise. "You’re wrong. You did help us win." The room shifted its attention to her and he cocked his head in confusion. Catra seemed slightly annoyed at having to suffer their attention, but continued after a lengthy eye-roll. "Even if you didn’t think we had a chance at winning, Prime was already in the heart, and it was killing Adora. Like, full-blown killing her. When you turned on him, you made him split his attention. He was too busy pontificating at everybody while destroying the planet to

stop me from… uh…" She blushed lightly for some reason and Adora suppressed a tight smile, "...helping her get the upper hand."

"There you go, Hordak," Swift Wind smiled. Hordak raised a brow at the talking horse. "Getting god to hate you so much that it's distracting has to count as a talent, right?"

"I'd call it a talent," Double Trouble offered.

"See?" Catra asked, smugly. "You helped by *just being yourself,* Hordak."

Nobody seemed to know how to continue after that. He looked back down at Entrapta, opened his mouth, and had no idea what to say. He was torn between apologizing for his useless effort at deflecting Prime's wrath, and asking her what in the unholy fuck was happening to his life. Whispering started up again and grew louder as the seconds passed.

Finally, an odd, high-pitched bark of sound broke up the hum of discussion. The sound happened a couple more times and as his body bounced with sporadic laughs, King Micah appeared to have completely lost his mind. "Ha! Ha ha ha! Ha ha!" He stared at Hordak with wide unblinking eyes as his face twisted further and his laughter intensified. Soon he was clutching his sides, roaring with uninhibited mirth. "I don't… believe," he choked out, barely controlling himself enough to speak. "You're telling me that Horde Prime; deathless, despotic, unchallenged master of the known universe," tears rolled down his face as he convulsed with suppressed laughter, "died because Lord Hordak; scourge of Etheria and terror of all nations," his voice reached an ever-higher pitch, "fell in love with *a princess* !" Hordak felt his ears flatten. "You served this guy your whole life, then you killed him… because he didn't like your girlfriend!" He collapsed into laughter again and slipped sideways off his chair, nearly falling to the floor before resituating himself.

“Dad,” Glimmer muttered, though she seemed to be having a hard time maintaining her stern demeanor.

Hordak opened his mouth to argue, at least for the sake of Entrapta’s reputation, but no words came to him. In fact, he realized with dawning alarm, he physically *couldn’t* argue with what the king had said, presumably because of the truth spell.

Catra began to laugh and Hordak felt his face burning. “Holy shit, look at him blush! I didn’t know he could do that!”

Once Adora’s composure cracked, the entire room joined in laughing. He did his best to endure with poise, but as he withdrew behind a cool demeanor, Entrapta whispered to him under the cover of laughter. “Do you really love me?” she asked from behind her mask, low enough that only he could hear.

He was still under the influence of the truth spell, but Hordak couldn’t imagine intentionally lying to her anyway. “Of course I do,” he answered softly.

When the commotion finally died and King Micah had recovered his composure, Princess Netossa spoke up. “So, do you remember everything now? Did it all come back?”

“I remember quite a bit,” he replied, “but it’s all very… fragmentary. Flashes of images, senses or feelings… it’s all disjointed and difficult for me to put back into order.” He wondered if he’d ever fully recover what Prime took. “And I get a headache every time I attempt to,” he added with a clenched jaw, wary of the clawing threat of another one.

“Do you guys think we could wrap this up soon? It’s already taking a lot longer than I thought it would,” Entrapta said cheerfully.

“Entrapta’s right,” Glimmer said, wiping her eyes. “We have a lot of other stuff to get to. Does anybody else have more to say?”

“Are you actually sorry?” Bow asked.

“Sorry?” Hordak began hoarsely, and he couldn’t help a stab of incredulity, “there are no words in your language to express the horror I feel at my own actions. The *scope* of the damage I have done is beyond my ability to comprehend, and it will surely endure long beyond my own lifespan. I am…” he faltered and growled in frustration, “I struggle to express the breadth of the regret I have only just begun to feel.” He lowered his head, too ashamed to meet anyone’s gaze.

“Are you sure that truth spell worked?” Princess Mermista muttered.

Hordak opened his eyes again in time to see King Micah stand and send another truth spell through him. He braced himself but again, felt nothing.

“Tell us again,” he said, staring at Hordak intently, “tell us the truth, to our faces.”

“I am so sorry for what I have done to you, all of you, and countless others,” Hordak replied, wishing he could express the enormity of his realizations.

Several people took deep breaths while they stared him down. Princess Perfuma grabbed Princess Scorpia’s arm and beamed at him.

“Anyone else want to say anything? Now’s your chance,” the Queen offered.

“Look,” Princess Mermista broke in, “you were right when you said your crimes are unforgivable. I will never, *ever* forgive you for what you did to my people or to Etheria. And I still don’t trust you. Part of me still thinks this is all going to pan out into some plot to recover power or some type of bullshit, but…” she trailed off, rolling her eyes and sighing heavily. “I am *so* ready to move on with my life. Like Glimmer said, we’ve got a lot of work to do." She rolled her eyes slowly and heaved another dramatic sigh. "And seeing as you owe it to us anyway, I *guess* I’m okay with

using you for your skills instead of wasting more of my time and energy on talking at you.” She finished, crossed her arms, and raised a challenging brow at him.

“Uh, I'd like to move on, too. I don't ever want to talk about Hordak’s personal issues ever again, thanks.” Catra added.

“Well? Do you have any desire or plans for further conquest? Any abuse of any kind?” King Micah asked him, folding his arms as well.

“None whatsoever,” Hordak replied. He couldn’t believe that after everything he’d told them, this was still how the meeting was wrapping up. He was so stunned it was disorienting. Though, he might be beginning to get used to being stunned and disoriented.

“Anyone else?” the queen asked again. “Anything left to say?” After no one replied she took a breath and continued. “Very well, then. Hordak, I hereby remand you into the custody and complete authority of Princess Entrapta. From this point forward, you will be subject to any and all scrutiny from any and all members of the Princess Alliance at any given time. Princess Entrapta, yourself, and all of your work together will be closely supervised into the foreseeable future. Do you understand?”

“Yes,” Hordak replied, nodding slowly.

“Entrapta?” the queen continued, “please figure out some kind of surveillance system so we can do all the stuff I just said and get it to the various members of the alliance ASAP.”

Entrapta cackled loudly, surprising everyone in the room, including Hordak. “Actually,” she said, flipping up her mask and smiling widely, “I maaay have anticipated this outcome and already done that. Wrong Hordak?” The clone smiled and handed her a kind of cuff with a screen on it. “This thingy fits over his armor, and I’ve already messaged you all with access to the channel I made for you to check in on Hordak whenever you want. You can test it out now, if you want to.”

Bow already had his data pad out and was tapping away. In a few seconds, the screen on the cuff that Entrapta was holding lit up with his face and voice as he said "hello? Is it working?"

Entrapta laughed in triumph. "Great!"

"Is everyone satisfied with that?" Glimmer asked the room at large.

An affirmative murmur went around the room.

Queen Glimmer nodded. "Okay then. I guess we're done with you for now, Hordak."

While Lance and George started chattering excitedly and King Micah suggested an ice cream break to Princess Mermista, Entrapta leapt up and started towing a still-stunned Hordak away. "I'll be back soon to help with stuff!" she called back past him. Wrong Hordak stayed behind, apparently filling an advisory role to the alliance.

Before they got to the doorway, he paused as Entrapta pulled him determinedly. "The soldiers," he called over his shoulder, "Etheria mustn't have large numbers of soldiers who are unemployed and battle-fatigued milling about. They need to transition from war to peacetime society, and they might need some assistance." Entrapta stopped pulling him by the arm and instead got behind him to push against the small of his back. "They have skills that can help in the reconstruction effort, and their fighting abilities might prove useful in keeping new transport lines safe from flora and fauna." He staggered a few steps forward as Entrapta pushed, incredibly strong for her size.

"Would you shut up already and stop trying to manage things? George is military and quite intelligent. We'll fetch you if we need you," she said in a strained voice, switching to push him with her shoulder. "Ha ha!" she laughed in triumph when she succeeded in pushing him through the exit with her hair pulling at the door

frame. The doors to the War Room shut as Entrapta switched back to leading him by his arm.

* * * * *

After they'd watched Entrapta physically force Hordak out of the meeting and the doors had shut behind them, the room remained in stunned silence. Catra could see quite a few mouths gaping open in shock, and she couldn't help but smirk for some reason. She caught Adora's eye and exchanged raised brows and small smiles, satisfied with how the meeting with Hordak had gone. Catra was also relieved it was over. Talking about Hordak's story had been painful, the memories it triggered were agonizing.

"Wwwow." Glimmer said. She seemed unsure of how to continue.

"Yeah," Mermista said.

"Fuckin' Entrapta," Catra muttered.

"That. Was. INCREDIBLE. No notes!" Double Trouble cried. "I haven't been so gripped by a plotline since we found out about Great Uncle Boris' second family!"

Catra rubbed her face, wearily. "Alright everybody, what's next?"

"Ooh!" Perfuma straightened in her seat, lightly clapping her hands together a few times. "How about we make up a mission statement! It could help with ideas and our self-representation goal!"

“I actually agree with that idea, but I think it can probably wait,” Glimmer said, shaking herself. “What’s the most urgent crisis?”

“Probably housing for the displaced, communication for the separated, and the clones,” Mermista droned, “but I’m about to join the king for an ice cream break, and I suggest we all take a few minutes to process the mess we just witnessed.”

As the room began to clear, she saw Double Trouble approach her languidly from the corner of her eye. She tensed for a moment at the memory of their last meeting. “Hello, Kitten. Good to see you alive and well.”

“Yeah, you too,” Catra muttered back.

“I was just checking to see if you still had hard feelings over my little Double Trouble double-cross there at the end of the lesser war.”

She huffed. "Is that what they're calling it, now? The lesser war?"

"Indeed," they replied. "Feels a little condescending, doesn't it?" They eyed her. "Now tell me if you're mad at me for betraying you."

Catra heaved a sigh and shrugged. “You were a big fucking bitch about it, but you told it like it was. And... I did kind of need to hear what you had to say." She looked back up at them and smiled wearily. "I think we all need friends as honest as you. At least one.” Double Trouble smiled wickedly and Catra frowned. “Maybe just one.”

“Hordak had more interesting things to say than usual. What did you think?” Double Trouble continued comfortably, and Catra relaxed.

“I think he’s being paranoid,” said Adora. “We’re the good guys. I don’t see why other planets would want to open hostilities. And as far as internal threats,” she scoffed, “what bad thing couldn’t we handle, now that we fought Prime and won?”

Catra heartily disagreed, but maybe she was being paranoid, too. In any case, whatever the future held, she just hoped she'd be able to see it through with her friends, new and old, if they'd have her. Entrapta still hadn't returned to the meeting, but Catra watched Scorpia as the large woman chatted animatedly with the preachy, flowery princess.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked.

Catra looked over at her and saw that Double Trouble was already gone. She shrugged. "I'm fine," she said, and again she knew her words were a lie. Something about seeing how damaged Hordak was made her feel sick, but also… afraid? She tried to shake of the feeling off as she met Adora's eyes.

"Catra." She looked up at Adora's intense gaze. "Please. Please share it with me."

Catra looked around them to make sure no one was listening and lowered her voice so that Adora had to lean in closer. "He's just... he was so messed up, you know? We did such... we were both, like..." she struggled to express feelings she did not yet understand.

"Does what he became scare you?" Catra sighed with relief as Adora kept up, despite her lack of communication skills. "Does it scare you to think about the path you were on?" Catra nodded and shut her eyes as Adora moved closer, slipping her hands into Catra's.

"I have to believe he can come back from that," she whispered against the sudden sting in her eyes. "I have to believe it for my sake."

Adora leaned her forehead against Catra's and hummed lowly. "You're not him. You're Catra. That's more than enough to be managing, right now."

She took a deep breath and shook herself mentally, trying to rally. "I know. You're right, and I know it." She shook her head and

took a small step back to meet Adora's eyes. "I'm going to do this right, Adora," she said, more for her own benefit than for the other woman's. "Things are going to be different. I'm going to do good, this time. I'm going to do it right." She set her jaw in a sudden feeling of urgency. She had so, *so* much to make up for.

Adora gave her a lopsided grin. "I know," she said simply. Catra smiled back.

A sudden burst of braying laughter caught their attention and they looked over to see a confused, if pleased Wrong Hordak bearing the attention of Swift Wind and Double Trouble. It seemed they were enjoying some kind of joke he didn't realize he'd made. "There'll be a lot less Entrapta around for him to hide behind," she muttered to Adora. "It'll be interesting to see how he handles it."

"Speaking of Entrapta," Adora said. Catra was relieved to feel the tone of conversation begin to lighten, “I honestly thought I’d hate it for some reason. You know, her and Hordak. But I don’t think I do,” she said, tilting her head and squinting up and away. “I mean, she’s definitely been good for him. What do you think about the other way around? Do you think he’s good for Entrapta?”

Catra snorted. "I wouldn't know. She was fully obsessed by the time we made friends. Before they even officially met, actually."

Adora raised her eyebrows. "You don't think she... I mean, she did spend a bunch of time in the vents, and we *know* she's into spying on people." Adora smirked knowingly.

"Ew- Adora!" Catra cried in protest, screwing up her face and shaking her head.

She laughed as Catra suffered and put up her hands in surrender. "Alright, alright. I'm done teasing."

Catra lifted her gaze to drink her in. Beautiful. Mischievous. Smiling. At *her* . She swallowed heavily. “I need a distraction,” she said in a low voice. She felt her ears lower as she gave Adora a

small smile. “Want to go make out in a closet or something?” Adora’s eyebrow raised and the corner of her mouth twitched. Her reaction made Catra’s breath catch as she leaned forward and whispered in her ear. “Just a little break? Relieve some stress and refocus our attention?” She smirked as Adora nodded hastily.

They wandered out of the room as casually as they could, but broke into a sprint the second they were out of sight in the hallway. Adora grabbed Catra’s hand and led her to a discrete cupboard. Catra looked down and smiled at the sight of their clasped hands, all thoughts of Hordak, the Velvet Glove, and *him* gone from her mind. Once Adora had closed the door behind them, Catra spun her around and shoved her up against it.

“I love you,” Catra said, kissing her urgently.

“I love you too, but are you okay?"

Catra sheathed her claws and dug her fingers into Adora's hair, looking into her eyes and setting her jaw. "I’m fine,” she said, and tried to give her a reassuring smile.

With her so close, it was much easier to settle her thoughts and return to the present. Adora cupped her face, and Catra forcibly pushed the memories her action triggered to the back of her mind, trying to focus on how warm and soft her hands were. She placed her fingers lightly over Adora's on her face and watched her eyelids grow heavy as she slowly leaned closer. She closed her own eyes and held her breath until she felt Adora's lips press gently to her own. “I love you,” Adora repeated in a voice barely above a whisper.

When Adora kissed her again she responded in earnest, moving her hands down to just below her waist, gripping the full, soft flesh there. Adora grunted in approval and grabbed back, giggling lightly. The sound stoked the fire in Catra’s lower belly and she shivered, gripping Adora's hip harder and letting a low growl slip. When a purr started up in Catra’s throat, Adora's kisses grew wetter, hungrier. When Catra parted her lips for her, Adora's

tongue plunged in and darted so deep it made her grasp before they fell into a passionate duel between their mouths.

The blonde wrapped her arms around Catra's neck and deepened their kiss, sighing contentedly. Catra bent briefly to grip one of Adora's thighs, hoisting up her knee to hook over her hip. Adora began to run her hands over her neck and shoulders, then down her front and sides, squeezing impulsively as her fingers roved. When she reached down and gripped Catras ass so hard her feet momentarily left the ground, Catra growled and started purring harder, kissing Adora with more urgency and pressing her hips up against hers.

Prime’s voice found her again; `... *you were never enough for her* ...' She snarled low and fierce as she determinedly pushed back the memories again, gripping Adora a bit harder with her claws than she should have as she dragged herself back to her.

With their mouths still locked together, she palmed Adora's breasts greedily, lifting and kneading them before she slipped one hand further down her torso. "I don't suppose you feel like a quickie?" she breathed against Adora's lips.

"We shouldn't," Adora groaned, and Catra could hear she was outright panting. She leaned in and kissed the scars on the bottom of Adora's jaw, and the other tilted her head back so Catra could access her throat.

Catra grazed her fangs along the side of Adora's neck and she shuddered hard, drawing in a shaky breath. "But you taste so good," Catra crooned beneath her ear.

"It's going to be awkward if we show up late," she mumbled feebly, but Catra knew the discussion was over.

"That seems like a problem for future Adora and Catra," she purred, nipping a little harder at Adora's neck before licking it lightly, slowly inching her palm lower on her abdomen. She dipped the tips of her fingers just below the waistband of Adora's pants.

"Let me touch you, feel you on my fingers," she whispered in the breathiest pout she could muster.

Adora gave her a beautiful, frustrated groan and nodded, whimpering slightly as Catra hurried to unfasten her pants. She slipped her fingers into Adora's underwear and growled deeply when skin met skin, reveling in how wet she already was.

Catra moved her lips back to Adora's and claimed her mouth with a searing kiss and swallowed her next sigh. She slipped her two middle fingers between Adora's swelling lips, claws carefully sheathed, and barely skimmed them up and down her slit, gathering the sweet moisture there. Adora's breath hitched when Catra brushed her clit, and she pushed Adora up against the door a bit harder, rolling her hips and trying to focus.

"Just a quickie then," Adora sighed, now smiling with her eyes lightly shut. Catra didn't bother using words to express her eager agreement.

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

“I don’t think anything can feel right... I don’t think it should.”

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta finally puts Hordak down for a nap and Catra joins the princesses in the planning phase of the day. The Rebellion surveys the contrasting struggles of Etherian war victims and newly freed clones.

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As Entrapta and Hordak walked away from the meeting, neither spoke. His mind raced with everything that had just transpired- with everything the princesses had said, with the pain he'd seen on their faces, with the endless reach of his actions. At the same time, he thought of how Scorpia, Catra and Adora were raised in his name, and how they’d all become heroes regardless. He thought of Wrong Hordak’s indelible character and genuine goodwill, and wondered at what kind of man he was, to have made all the opposite choices. But still, Hordak had been given mercy, which was the most disorienting facet of the entire situation. Nothing the princesses were doing made sense to him. He could no longer understand the chain of cause-and-effect in the behavior of the beings around him, and the confusion left him feeling dazed.

He looked down at Entrapta, and to the gloved hand still grasping his firmly. So much more important than his singular, petty struggles, the future of Etheria loomed great and unknowable.

Etherians were more vulnerable in this moment than anyone seemed to realize, and panic threatened at the edges of his mind. He was not a creative enough person to imagine all the troubles that might possibly land in their orbit, now that the rest of the universe had access to them. Their most immediate concerns were more than enough to be getting on with, but what he hadn't brought himself to remind them was that Prime was not without allies, far away though they were.

It wasn’t until Entrapta had led him all the way back to the rebel camp and into her tent that she turned and looked up at him. As he gazed down at her, he realized that in some ways, he was seeing her for the first time. For so long, she'd been a mysterious vision from an exotic world. She was still a magical princess, but now they again they stood as friends and partners. She'd wanted to share a future with him, and if she still did, he now had a future to share.

Her golden brown skin seemed to glow all it's own in the dim light within her tent. For a brief moment he wondered at the color of her eyes. Were they soft red? Magenta? Fuchsia? He could swear the hue shifted by the second. When she smiled up at him, he felt like he'd just taken a gulp of something very warm and could feel it trickling through his torso. She blinked. He stared back, dumbly.

Entrapta opened her mouth, shut it, then rose on her hair to press a chaste kiss against his cheek. He felt his face burn as she lowered herself back to the floor. “You know I love you too, right?” His hearts started pounding again and he gulped. She smiled up at him again as she continued, “I’ve loved you for a long time, Hordak. It’s what the crystal says. I loved you even back then. Even though I knew it was problematic and didn’t know what to do about it," she paused to shrug, "like I said before, I just couldn’t help it.” She removed her gloves and stuck them in the waistband of her overalls before slowly taking the hand on his good arm in both her bare hands. “Do you know why I never helped Wrong Hordak chose a name?”

This did strike him as odd. Entrapta named everything in her life, from robots to spacecraft- it was one of her quirks. He shook his head no.

“It’s because I was going to find you, no matter what it took, and when I did find you and you were freed,” she looked away but smiled sweetly, “I didn’t want you to think you’d been replaced.” His hand twitched in hers and he stopped breathing again. “Horde Prime said that you were useless. I know that where you come from, that means worthless. That’s why I wrote what I did on your crystal.” She moved her fingers over his, turning his hand over and brushing over the creases on his palm. “On Etheria, you don't have to prove your worth in order to matter. And to me... you’re priceless to me- irreplaceable and loved."

He finally forced himself to answer her in a hoarse voice. “I don’t deserve any of this. After the things I’ve done...”

She shrugged again and looked at his hand. “Maybe you don’t deserve all this mercy. Maybe I don’t either. It’s hard to say if any of us ex-villains do. But for me, loving somebody isn’t about deservedness. At least not for me.” She looked back up at him. “The love part isn’t about what you’ve done in the past or might yet do. I just… love *you* . We love each other.” She looked up at him and he felt his eyes burning again. “And I think we can turn that into something really good, if we work hard on it together. And,” she paused for a beat, still holding eye-contact, “Hordak, I am so, so proud of you.”

Hordak froze, he stopped breathing again and his mind seemed to slow. *That* . That right there. If there was anything in the world that he truly, selfishly wanted for himself, it was this. He wanted to be the kind of man to make Entrapta proud. The kind of man that was worthy of her love.

She smiled again and he had the sudden urge to laugh. Everything he’d ever been certain of had been proven to be illusion, and as frightened as he’d been, it turned out that he didn’t mind at all. He was completely untethered, lost in the chaos

that Prime had taught him to fear, but still somehow anchored to the best thing that had ever happened to him. He impulsively brought his free hand up to her face, though he stopped just short of touching her. She leaned her head into his palm, however, and they both held still for several moments. “This can’t really be happening,” he murmured in helpless disbelief.

“Sure it can. This is Etheria, and magical things happen here all the time,” she turned and kissed his palm before gently shoving him toward the cot. “But right now, I’ve got projects to attend to, and you need rest. So rest! Or else I’m going to sic the princesses on you,” she warned. "Lab shower is in the corner," she pointed one piece of hair, "the bed is there," she pointed with another piece of hair. "But I've got to get going, I'm picking up signs of life from the Velvet Glove, which means there's still some clones up there.' At this, his breath caught and she noticed. Her face fell slightly and he saw trepidation enter her expression. "What is it?" she asked gently, as if she weren't afraid of what he'd say.

He hesitated, glad that the truth spell was starting to work slower. "Entrapta," he said seriously. She looked into his eyes, brow creased. "By all means, please retrieve the remaining clones. But... anything else you find up there..." He paused again and her expression grew more worried. "Whatever you happen upon, you're not going to like it."

She squeezed his hand before nodding. "It's okay, Hordak. It needs to be handled, and we're going to handle it."

"Thank you," he said quietly, holding his bad arm close to his chest.

A few seconds passed before Entrapta spoke again. “Huh. It’s still really weird to see you in pants.” She looked him up and down with a frown.

“I hate pants,” he muttered at the shower, eyeing it longingly. He felt a kiss on his cheek, but when he turned around she was already halfway out of the tent, canvas flap falling behind her.

* * * * *

Later that day, Catra was back in the War Room with the other princesses, and she could tell that everyone was starting to get tired, which meant they would soon be irritable. She'd been mostly silent after Hordak had left, struggling to stay present while daydreams of her night with Adora beckoned. She didn't realize she'd been absorbed by the memory of Adora's thighs pressed against her ears until Glimmer had literally snapped for her attention.

Catra, however, was eager for any chance to be helpful, and she was glad that she had experience to offer when it came to discussion around supply lines and systems by which aid operations could be tracked and managed. Part of getting a handle on the needs to be met, however, was reviewing them. She'd cringed under the sidelong glances as representatives testified to their peoples' staggering privation, and knew that no matter how stark life had been in the horde, she'd never been in want the ways her victims had.

At first, Catra was jealous of Entrapta and Scorpia, who'd escaped the ordeal by making an impromptu run with Wrong Hordak in Darla to retrieve whatever clones Entrapta said were still on the Velvet Glove. At least, she'd been jealous until they'd returned a couple hours later.

She had assumed that hearing people talk of the pain she'd been directly responsible for would be the worst of it, but hearing about the plight of the clones was just as difficult. They had returned from the Velvet Glove looking deeply upset less than two hours after they'd left. With them, they had a handful of clones that Bow

and Swift Wind had organized the day before in hopes that they might be able to answer questions for the gathered Etherians. Entrapta had plunked into her seat and closed in upon herself with her mask down, but Scorpia had offered a few meaningful looks that suggested that what they'd seen on the Velvet Glove had been unpleasant. Nobody pressed the subject.

All clones were trained fighters, but they'd also filled a myriad of roles outside of combat and seemed to have generally quiet and pious values. Well, besides the whole conversion-by-conquest thing. Granted, it was impossible to forget that one was in the presence of an apex predator while sharing space with a clone, but they were shockingly well-mannered and attentive. They were also achingly, gut-wrenchingly tender toward one another. Their bond showed in the way they clustered close, or gently touched one another at signs of distress. They were even beginning to allow their ears to emote while talking with one another.

Frankly, she had no clue how Hordak had become such an insufferable twat, because every other clone she encountered was… well, darling. Unless they were disturbingly damaged. And she was beginning to realize there were a great many damaged clones.

For the most part, it seemed to Catra that the clones just wanted to be useful- which was an impulse she could sympathize with. They were disoriented and frightened and generally in pretty bad emotional shape, but it was the ones who wouldn't talk about their existences under Prime that were the hardest for Catra to see. From stolen glances between wide eyed observers, she could tell she wasn't the only one who was starting to get overwhelmed by their tragedy. She couldn't yet bring herself to contemplate how nightmarish it must have been for those few that Prime kept closest.

Catra could hardly stand it. He was dead. He was gone. And yet, the sheer malignance of Horde Prime was still revealing itself, manifesting around them all into an inescapable mire. She wasn't

free. She'd escaped his consciousness, but not his sickening reach.

She'd sat with her head in her hand, fingers knotted in her short hair, with her other hand wrapped loosely around Adora's as the room discussed which princesses could take in how many of which refugees. It was agreed that the clones in their care should stay together for a time, there at Bright Moon to keep it simple. Now she gently ran her clawed thumb over Adora's knuckles and listened as the princesses discussed Hordak's suggestions about PR and their new intergalactic neighbors. Bow had suggested some kind of outgoing message along the lines of the one he'd given across Etheria via Prime's gigantic holograms. Now the room was trying to think of what Etheria might want to say first to the universe at large, mindful that they were already intergalactic celebrities and an unwitting ideological inspiration.

Frosta spoke, growing grumpy and weary of the day's long, depressing work. "Why don't we just, like, sum up the stuff we decided on today?" she suggested, gesturing her hand lazily but peering at them with alert intent. Catra thought back to Princess Prom and calculated that Frosta must be around fourteen by now. She was suddenly amazed at Frosta's tenacity and responsibility. In the Fright Zone, Incoming Cadets had seemed so much younger than Catra and Adora had been at the same stage, impossibly childish and obnoxious. Frosta was the opposite. Certainly childishness shone through at times, but in her abilities and bearing, she held her own around much older princesses, keeping pace with all they did.

It took forever, but when they were ready to call it a day, Catra felt more confident in their preparedness as a team than she had yet. It was late in the evening when the motley assembly slowly filtered out into the spacious hall beyond. Frosta led the crowd at top speed, disappearing around the hall corner before the War Room was empty. Off to do 14-year-old-stuff, Catra hoped.

Adora started talking to Perfuma and Scorpia, but Catra wasn't in much of a mood to chat. She wandered a little ways away,

wondering idly where Melog was and looking at the soaring murals on the high walls. Much to her frustration, Hordak's words were still haunting her. So much damage had been done, so much of it was permanent, and so much of it was her fault. She wanted to be complicit in justice too, but she didn't know if she could be. She'd be lying if she pretended she cared about Etheria more than, for instance, Adora, but she could still help, right? She would try, anyway. She would try.

* * * * *

Hordak slept dreamlessly until evening when he heard Entrapta return, riding atop Emily and chatting happily with the bot. The sight made him miss Imp, but it was a joy to behold regardless.

He wasn't able to greet her before Wrong Hordak followed her in, carrying a large basket. "Greetings, brother!" he cried, too loudly.

Hordak was shocked to see more people file through the door after him. Princesses Perfuma, Scorpia, Frosta, Netossa, and Spinnerella were followed closely by Catra and Adora, carrying several folding chairs. They were followed by a large feline alien the likes of which he had never seen, but seemed attached to Catra. He was still clothed in his undersuit, but he yanked the covers up over his chest reflexively.

"Calm down, Hordak. Nobody's here to beat you up," mocked Catra.

"We're here for dinner, Actually," said Swift Wind, who ended the procession of people and sat down heavily in the doorway.

“Dinner?” he asked, weakly. He stared in horror at the crowd that he was in no way ready to face.

“You are underweight and need sustenance, brother.” Wrong Hordak said as he pulled a blanket from the basket and laid it out across the floor. “But fear not! Bright Moon’s kitchens have provided us with a bounty!” He set the basket down on the blanket and began to unpack it as Catra and Adora set up chairs.

Once everyone was settled either on the floor, in chairs, or perched atop other furniture, Hordak tried speaking again. “I don’t think I understand. Don’t you customarily eat in some sort of Dining Commons?”

“This is called a picnic!” Princess Scorpia said cheerily.

“But, why here?”

Several of the people present exchanged looks.

“You are *not* off the hook for what you did,” Princess Netossa said, “but…”

“But,” Princess Spinnerella broke in, “we know because of the truth spell that you’re sorry, and that you want better for Etheria.”

“And if you’re on the side of Etheria, then you and I are on the same side again!” Princess Scorpia added enthusiastically.

“But,” Hordak said, scowling.

“Being on the same side means having each other’s backs, even if you’re not forgiven,” Princess Netossa said with a raised brow.

“So a few of us came to see how you were doing, and maybe get to know you a little better, see what Entrapta was talking about,” Princess Perfuma offered.

Hordak didn’t respond as Wrong Hordak pressed a heavily laden plate into his lap.

"We all know what it's like to have regrets," Adora said through a full mouth before gulping loudly, "but being a part of our team means you don't have to deal with those regrets alone."

He couldn't take more generosity, laying in one of Bright Moon's tents, eating their food, and spurring their worst memories. He began shaking his head in growing dismay and frustration.

"Look," Catra broke in, "watching the other princesses be amazing even makes *me* want to be better. Glimmer is treating me like one of her own even after what I did to her mom. And if Mermista and Micah can move forward with what you did to them, then *I* want to." She looked over at him with an unusually sad expression. "You're still the bad guy in a lot of my nightmares, Hordak." He opened his mouth, unsure of how to reply, but she didn't let him. "But I'm the bad guy in most of them. And… I feel like, in that much at least, we're in a similar boat. And it really, really fucking sucks." She looked away and shrugged. "But it's also not the end of the world." She ran a hand through her cropped hair as Adora gave her a fond look. "For what it's worth, I'm sorry for pushing you toward escalating depravity after I gave Entrapta the death sentence she saved me from."

Hordak actually snorted. He still felt a swell of rage and grief over what he'd let her do to Entrapta, but it was nothing compared to the other emotions he'd been awash in all day. In fact, he felt as if he'd exceeded some kind of emotional saturation limit, beyond what he could process for the time being. He couldn't help scowling, but he forced himself to speak. "And I apologize for terrorizing you your entire life and teaching you to repeat all of my mistakes." Catra raised her eyebrows in mild surprise. "All of you," he added, looking between Catra, Adora, and Princess Scorpia. "Even so, you've done so much better than I ever did. You should be very proud of yourselves." Was that too dramatic? He felt one of his eyes twitch. It sounded too dramatic when he'd said it out loud.

Much to his alarm, Princess Scorpia burst into tears and Princess Perfuma comforted her in confusion. Adora and Catra exchanged

taken aback glances. “Huh,” Catra said, looking at the floor and shifting in her seat. “Do I actually…? Wow. I think I actually feel better,” she said in shocked disbelief.

“I told you a sincere apology goes a long way,” Perfuma beamed. Even Princess Netossa’s countenance softened as Princess Spinnerella leaned into her and smiled.

“It’s kind of weird to see you in bed,” Catra observed while chewing something aggressively. “I honestly thought you didn’t sleep. Especially seeing as you don’t need as much air as we do.”

His face twisted in angry shame and he looked away, cursing himself for his lowering ears. He hcated everything about his current position- reclining in his undersuit in a tent full of princesses. Thankfully, Entrapta cut in. “Oh he sleeps all the time, it’s just hard to tell.”

“What?” Perfuma asked in confusion.

“Well,” Entrapta said, not looking up from the work on her datapad, “more like napping. And his eyes stay open- at least, one set of eyelids does. So he can nap while sitting up but it just looks like he’s brooding. He only enters deep sleep or dreams when he’s fully unconscious.”

Several of the princesses shuddered and Swift Wind said “oh, oh no. That is deeply unnerving.”

“Okay well,” Princess Frosta piped up, “honestly, I just want to hear more about how you killed Prime.” A wicked glee entered her face and he gulped.

Entrapta rescued him again and took over the story, to his relief. “Oh he was amazing! You wouldn’t believe it, he…”

Hordak tuned out Entrapta’s words for once as he watched the others drink in her story with rapt attention, casting him surprised looks. All of them listened, but Wrong Hordak was watching him while doing so. It was still impossible to read his expression, and

Hordak had to wonder how he felt about a fellow clone killing their exalted brother.

After Entrapta finished the short tale and changed subjects, the entire assembly badgered Hordak to eat as much as he could. It took a bit of stern insisting to convince them that he couldn't possibly take another bite once he'd made a dent in his plateful. They all told him that he didn't have to use their royal titles in casual conversation though he intended to do so anyway, Spinnerella gave Entrapta and Hordak a soup recipe that Netossa was partial to, and Perfuma and Scorpia gave them several recipes for teas which they claimed might help with Hordak's various aches and pains.

The ex-horde soldiers finished their food first, and without explanation Adora suddenly stood and transformed into the She-Ra with a blinding flash of light. It greatly surprised Hordak, who squinted at her in bewilderment, but everyone else seemed completely unfazed.

She-Ra walked over to him with an apologetic expression. "Sorry I haven't done anything about it until now, but I wanted to heal the injuries you have from the battle. I already did everybody else's."

"My injuries?" he asked defensively as Entrapta rose and came to stand at his other side.

"Well, that and your whole…" she seemed unsure of her words, "cloning flaw issue. Defect."

He nodded and held Entrapta's gaze as She-Ra placed a large, gentle hand on his injured shoulder. He couldn't stop a low hiss and shrank away from her touch instinctively, but he stilled himself as she kept her movements slow and gentle. She began to glow, the light extended onto him, and in a mere moment the lingering pain throughout his left side was gone, though his body still felt incredibly fatigued. She-Ra, however, lingered at his side, glowing and staring in confusion.

Finally, she let go and the light emanating from her dimmed down. “Huh, that’s weird,” she said, cocking her head at him while he met her gaze, rolling his shoulder experimentally. For some reason, Entrapta gripped his arm in excitement. “I handled the soft-tissue damage, but… I couldn’t change the long-term stuff. It was just, like, *part* of you. Sorry Hordak, but that’s all I’ve got.” She shrugged and shook her head lightly.

To everyone’s surprise, Entrapta cackled and clapped in delight. “See?” she exclaimed in a high-pitch squeal. “I was right! You aren’t *defective,* you’re just built different.” He stared back at her, still hopelessly confused. She beamed at him “Some people are built different, Hordak. It’s not always easy, but it’s *fine* . The universe is just chaotic like that.” She threw her arms around his neck and cackled some more as he blushed and patted one of her arms awkwardly. To his renewed horror, Scorpia started crying again and Spinnerella also seemed misty-eyed. He scowled as fiercely as he could and wished he still had the power to threaten them into behaving themselves. She-Ra transformed back into Adora and gave him a warm smile before returning to the rest of the group, followed shortly by Entrapta, who hadn’t yet finished her tiny portions. Hordak could only stay silent as he mulled over the implications of She-Ra’s inability to heal him.

The others didn’t stay long after they’d finished eating. Swift Wind, Catra and Adora excused themselves first. Adora addressed him once more before leaving. “I’m glad you made it, Hordak. I mean it.”

Frosta left with Netossa and Spinnerella just after giving Hordak a bright wave on her way out. Finally, Scorpia followed Perfuma, calling over her shoulder that she might have some clothing that could fit Hordak’s broad shoulders. She held the flap open for Wrong Hordak, who carried the dishes and leftovers from the meal with the giant basket they’d brought in, calling warm farewells back over his shoulder at them. Hordak might have imagined it, but he thought he saw him wink at them.

When he and Entrapta were alone in her room again. He glanced over at her, and she was already looking at him. “Was that difficult for you?” she asked, curiously.

He thought for a moment. “Not in the ways I would have expected,” he answered, letting his brow bunch together as he considered.

“How was it hard?”

Hordak hesitated, hoping she’d change the subject, but it seemed she was curious. “I can’t stop thinking about what I’ve done. It makes everything that’s happening feel… wrong. I’m trying to do what they want, but I… I can’t imagine going forward as if everything is fine. I just can’t do it,” he said, searching her face.

After a brief pause, Entrapta said “well, what would you rather be doing? What would feel right?” She approached slowly until she sat on the end of the bed, next to his legs.

“I don’t think anything can feel right,” he said, struggling to find the words he needed. “I don’t think it should.”

She furrowed her brows and dropped her eyes to his shoulder. “Hordak,” she began slowly, “do you still want to be with me? Even if you don’t want to be *with me,* with me, I… I should have asked earlier.” She bit her lip. “You’ve never been free before… I still mean it, what I said about helping you leave if you want to.” She scooted up toward him as she spoke, coming within easy reach.

He looked away and tried to reason out his jumbled thoughts and feelings. “I don’t want to lose you,” he finally said. “I can’t. I… I can’t.”

“Then I’m not going anywhere.”

He looked back into her eyes. “Is it selfish to want you? To be happy when I’m with you?”

Entrapta's determined look faded. "That's another question I don't have the answer to." She puzzled for a few moments. "But," she said, and a smile crept back through her features, "I do know that I don't care. I learned so much on Beast Island, Hordak, but one of the most important things I realized was that life is too short to not make the most of the good times." She took her gloves off slowly, deliberately, and lifted a hand to his face, giving him time to pull away. "I regretted a lot of stuff by then, but one regret that's bugged me ever since was that I didn't tell you how I felt when I still had you. Whatever you'd have done with that data, at least I would have known instead of wondering."

He pressed his hand over hers on his cheek. "I'm here now."

"I know you've been through a lot since… well, everyone has. And this time I'll be more mindful, I'm better at that now, and you can call the pacing, even if you decide you don't want to be as intimate as we were." Her eyes were earnest and her words were ready, she betrayed none of the begrudging compromise he would have assumed and eclectic. He slowly threaded their fingers on his cheek, squeezing her hand gently. "The way I see it, our moral compasses could both use some tweaking. I don't think there's anything wrong with two imperfect people trying to help each other be better." She smiled and rubbed her thumb back and forth across his cheekbone softly. "In addition! Our collaborations as partners have always been more extraordinary than our solo work."

He closed his eyes and leaned into the touch. "I'm still not sure how to approach… anything, in this new life. Including our relationship." He opened his eyes and looked back at her while she stared at one of his knees. "For now, I think I'd like to keep our public interactions strictly casual."

"Okay," Entrapta hesitated, "I'm completely fine with that. I just want to be clear, and it's fine if you are, but… are you… are you ashamed?"

“No! No, no of course not,” he said earnestly, leaning toward her, “it’s just that the thought of King Micah watching me benefit from what I took from him… I don’t want to do that. I stole the time he had left with Angela,” he said. He thought about the way Queen Glimmer had said ‘dad’ during the hearing that morning. “I stole his son’s childhood from him, too.”

“Daughter,” Entrapta corrected gently. He’d never fully gotten a handle on Etherian gender.

After a while, she stopped moving her thumb and tilted his face back up to look at her. “We’re going to work hard, and we’re going to beat what’s hurting you, memory by memory. I promise. But for now?” She withdrew her hand and fluffed up the pillow he’d been using. “You still need more rest. So lay down and relax.” She smiled at the pillow she was fussing with and warmth radiated upon him.

He realized how tired he still was even after sleeping through the day and lowered himself in bed. Only then did he process that her camp bed had been modified to hold someone of his huge stature, and his hearts swelled with affection. He looked over at her as she sat beside him, the way she moved, her shape…

Maybe Hordak wasn’t so tired after all. And maybe he wasn’t past his emotional saturation limit, either. He certainly had some strong feelings over the thought of touching her bare flesh again. How different would it be? How wonderful to finally have time, and hope, and a future he actually wanted. Then, unbidden and sickening, Prime’s malicious grinning face flashed across his mind and he cringed miserably. Maybe it would be different in a bad way.

It wouldn't be how it should, that much he was sure of. Entrapta was a creature of joy and love. His version of these things had been so thoroughly mutilated that he couldn't trust himself to reconstruct an unblemished version. He didn't know how to return the gifts she gave him. Even if he did know how, would be be able to? Could one so brutalized truly be capable of love? Of real, true

connection? But then again, what did that have to do with anything anymore? He would do anything for her. Anything at all. That was all that mattered at this point. Everything he could offer.
.

Luckily, Entrapta didn’t notice his gloomy musing as she realized she’d forgotten to change for bed. She chattered into her recorder about the day's progress as she lifted herself up and away across the room to tie the tent flaps shut from the inside. She began to undress in order to bathe, proving rather than insisting that she still trusted him implicitly, even after everything that had been said and done.

His hearts constricted when he realized she was thinner than she’d ever seen her, and she stooped toward him with exhaustion. He should have noticed how worn she was earlier. As she continued to remove clothes, he turned his head away modestly, blushing at the memories she was bringing back to him. Intimate moments they’d shared during their brief time together in the Fright Zone swam before his eyes, and he swallowed against the continued burning in his face and ears. On some level, he still couldn’t believe how far he’d gone for her. Those few precious nights when, riding a hormonal high and drunk on long-dormant instincts, he’d actually managed to stop thinking and shut everything else out. He had allowed himself to play-pretend as a *person* , rather than a cog in an unstoppable machine.

He didn't have long to agonize, however. Hordak soon fell back into an uneasy sleep to the sound of her meager camp shower.

* * * * *

He was back in his Sanctum, and Entrapta was approaching him for the first time with her proposal for increased physical contact between one another. She was playing with her hair and twisting

back and forth on her feet, rambling something about obvious distractions affecting productivity. She looked up at him from under her lashes, smiling shyly. She was so beautiful, so gentle, so kind. The way she fluttered those lavender lashes when she didn't hide her nerves behind a mask...

Then the scene froze and ice-cold dread flooded his body. He felt a large, clawed hand on the back of his neck, vicelike and painful, before Prime forced him to his knees. He trembled on all fours, trying not to cringe away from the grip on his neck or the barely-contained resentment radiating from behind him. After a few moments of tightly controlled breathing from above, the hand on his neck loosened and lifted.

As he heard Prime's footfalls head toward Entrapta, he looked up to see him prowling around her, looking her up and down with a small, politely puzzled smile. "I must admit that your attachment to this one is intriguing. I normally find beings that carry magic in their bodies to be…" he lifted one of the metal claws he wore on his index fingers until the back of it hovered just millimeters from Entrapta's cheek, "distasteful." He lowered his hand down her face without touching her. "However," he glanced at Hordak lazily and moved his finger until the tip of it hovered just a hair's breadth from her bottom lip, "your memories prove that she is, indeed, a fascinating specimen. I think I'd like to see what you found so very irresistible about her." He bared his canines in his joyless smile and his expression grew overtly predatory. Hordak's hearts began to pound again and he was *desperate* to get him away from Entrapta- real or not… but he was far too much of a coward to do anything about it. "I might just have to open this one up," Prime dragged his metal claw down through Entrapta's face, causing a glitching effect that left her image rent in two, "see what makes her tick, as it were." He withdrew his hand and stalked toward Hordak slowly.

"I'm sorry, Brother, please forgive me. I'm so sorry, I…" he was groveling again, even though he knew Prime hated it, *especially* coming from him. Prime's countenance shone with pure loathing.

“And you. You, who should never have been. Your befouled form did not please me, so you found some filthy savage to please instead?” Hordak leaned back on his heals, flinching away as Prime wrapped a hand around his throat, squeezing just hard enough to stop his breathing or speaking.

“Disgusting. You are a sickening corruption of everything I ever gave you.” His hand slowly loosened and as he bent Hordak’s neck back, exposing the length of his throat. His grip slackened further and he ran his thumb gently down the side of his neck. In the same manner that Entrapta used to.

Hordak shuddered and tasted his mouth turn acidic with bile. “The wages of sin is death, brother. But I am merciful, and I am generous. Even after so much failure, I will receive you back into my flock. Cleanse you. Purify you. But first, you must learn from your transgressions.” Again, that joyless smirk. “Rejoice, dear brother, for the wisdom I am about to grant you.”

“Please,” Hordak said in a weak voice as he trembled harder than ever, teeth chattering as one hand gripped Prime’s wrist, the heel of his other hand pushing against Prime’s hip, trying to maintain some distance.

Hordak fought tears and nausea as Prime continued. “’Hordak.’ The blasphemy. The arrogance. Hordak. *Hordak* . Like a rancid taste in one’s mouth.” He suddenly grasped Hordak’s hair tightly with his free hand and jerked his head backward. Hordak gasped in pain, shuddering as he heard the unnervingly wet sound of Prime’s lips sliding back across his teeth. Hordak instinctively took the hand from Prime’s hip to grasp at the hand pulling his hair and forcing his head back.

Prime took the opportunity to step closer so that he stood with both feet braced wide apart between Hordak's knees on the floor. “I’m sorry,” Hordak sobbed. “Please! *Please* , I can be better. I’m so sorry. Please, I'm so sorry.” Prime took the hand from his neck, but he kept Hordak's head tilted back, leaving his neck bare.

Prime ever so gently dragged his metal-clad claw down the side of Hordak's face, then along his jawline to hook him under the chin.

"Hordak! *Hordak* !" He vaguely realized that it wasn't Prime saying his name anymore, it was coming from further away. "Hordak! Please! Hordak!"

Hordak finally gasped raggedly as he startled awake, scrambling away from the person hovering over him until he fell, sprawling on the canvas floor. "N-no…" he said distractedly, shielding himself with one raised arm, claws out as he tried to get his bearings. Adrenaline surged through him and he wretched lightly, but managed to keep from getting sick. He was trembling convulsively, teeth chattering and abdomen spasming painfully. He was still gasping for breath and panting, and he could vaguely hear other voices outside of the tent, murmuring anxiously.

"It's okay, It's okay," Entrapta whimpered, tears streaming down her face. He looked back at her between darting his gaze around the room, realizing she was drenched and her hair was still a soapy mass down her body. Tears were in her eyes and she looked distraught. She had her hands raised in front of her, but was hesitant to reach toward him, for which he was grateful. He slowly lowered his arm. "You're here with me. You're safe." She let out another stressed whine and looked around herself again as if she might spot something that could help him. "I promise you're safe. I've got you, I promise I've got you.. "

He couldn't bear the anguish on her face. "I'm sorry," he said, calming down enough for the humiliation and despair to start bubbling up past the adrenaline. His eyes burned as Entrapta shook her head fiercely. "I'm sorry, I…"

"No! Don't ever apologize for this," she insisted. He couldn't keep his face from crumpling and he curled in on himself, sitting with his arms folded on his knees and his face buried between them. He held his breath and screwed up his face, biting the inside of his cheek as he felt her wet hands and soapy hair on his extremities, moving uncertainly.

She changed tac and rose to speak through the canvas entrance of the tent. “He’s fine, we’re fine, just a bad nightmare. You know how it can be.” The crowd did indeed seem to know, and began to disperse. Entrapta returned to his side and sank to her knees before wrapping her arms tightly around him. Her embrace was protective, not possessive, and he could stomach it regardless of the soap. “I’ve got you. I’ve got you, and I love you so much. I still want you as much as I ever did. I love you.” He could tell she was still fighting tears as well and leaned to cling to her as she held him. He hid his face between his arm and her still-wet chest, terrified that somebody might walk in before he regained control of himself. “It’s okay,” Entrapta cooed frantically, pressing her lips into his hair. “We’re okay.”

After a while he got ahold of himself and leaned away from her, sweeping his hair out of his face. “Forgive me, that was... embarrassing.”

“Hordak! Don’t you *ever* apologize for what you’ve been through. I mean it.” He looked at her, shocked by her angry tone. Her eyes were burning fiercely as she continued, “What Prime did to you was not your fault. What he did was never your fault. You’re taking responsibility for what *you’ve* done, not for what’s been done to you. Never. Not ever.”

He didn’t know how to reply, so he hung his head and focused on regaining composure. “I didn’t mean to make you cry,” he said eventually.

“You didn’t make me cry. Prime did, because I knew you were hurting and I couldn’t make it stop.” She chuckled wetly. “It took a while to wake you up. You’re such a light sleeper, up until you get sucked into a nightmare.” She stroked his face gently with one of her small hands. "I'm going to finish rinsing off real quick, and then I'll be back, okay?"

Hordak nodded, keeping his eyes on the floor.

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

"...I love you more than the stars."

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta helps Hordak take some time in his body, rather than in his thoughts. Nudge nudge.
> (entrapdak smut ahead)

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Entrapta exited the shower a few minutes later, he was still sitting on the bed, head in his hands, thinking hard. When she was dressed in bedclothes and her hair had brushed itself out, she crawled into the side he wasn't sitting on. He looked around at her and was relieved to see that her eyes weren't red from crying any more. Yet… she *had* cried. She had appeared frightened. Prime's malignant touch had reached her, whether he liked it or not, and it had reached her through him. He was still tracking Prime with him wherever he went, like the corruption he'd recognized Hordak to be. No… no. No need to be so dramatic. He could handle this. He just needed a little bit more time. He would simply have to make it up to her in the interim.

She patted the bed beside her with a hopeful expression and Hordak settled in next to her, reclining in her extraneous pillows until he was nearly horizontal. She pulled his arm out and rested the crook of her neck on it, the weight of her head on her pillow. Then she scooted closer until her arms were folded against his chest, and she nestled into place there against him, as if there were nowhere she'd rather be than in his arms. The strong smell

of her soaps was bold in his sinuses, and they both breathed deeply as he shifted his face to lean his forehead against her damp hairline.

“I missed you so much,” she told him again. “I missed this.”

“I love you,” he tried, impulsively. It was still difficult for him to say, but it was also thrilling.

“I love you too,” she said, and he could tell from her voice that she was smiling. He could also tell she was thinking about saying more, mulling over her words and deciding for or against speaking them aloud.

“What?” he coaxed, keeping his voice low and gentle, thinking about how near their bodies were. He could feel her warmth combining and building, could practically feel her impossible softness against his skin.

“Okay, so everything I said about pacing still stands, and it’s *totally* okay if you don’t want it, but… um…" Entrapta scrunched her face before trying a different approach. "Now, I get why you want to keep public interactions casual, now that you've explained... but… how about private interactions?”

He sighed slowly and couldn’t quite repress his slow grin. “That’s another matter entirely,” he rumbled. Entrapta bit her bottom lip and smiled back at him, her face resting against his bony chest, sending little thrills of heat through his entire body. His breathing deepened as he inhaled her smells. “Strange creature,” he murmured, incredulous that such a beautiful light to be attracted to… *him* .

She slowly reached a hand up to the side of his face, giving him time to deny her. He nearly jumped at the sudden burst of feeling that hit him when her bare fingertips brushed along his ear. As her touch trailed down against his cheek, however, he closed his eyes and tried to relax beneath her father-light fingertips. “I’m so glad I have you back,” she murmured as her finger trailed along his jaw.

He opened his eyes, trying to focus on her instead of her unwitting re-tracing of his nightmare.

When Entrapta moved her hand to feel the mottled skin on his neck and trailed a thumb down his throat, he lost his nerve and flinched back. "Fuck," he hissed as he sat up and felt the hollow surge of adrenaline thud into him, frustrated and angry with himself immediately. He looked back at her and saw confusion in her eyes. "I'm sorry," he said hastily, "I'm so sorry I can't stop... I keep letting... ruining things, even now." Shame trickled over his frustration, further disorienting him.

"Hordak, nothing is ruined," Entrapta insisted.

"I know I let you go, I was so stupid and it's been so long, but I can't…"

"Hordak," she said, now sitting up beside him.

He sat up too and rested his forehead in one of his hands. "I don't know how to *fix* it."

"*Hordak,*" He finally fell silent. "You don't have to fix anything. I love you, whether you're ready for a sexual relationship or not."

"But…"

"I'm perfectly capable of keeping myself sexually satisfied, thank you very much." She gave him a mischievous smile. "I rather enjoy my own company, in fact. So this isn't about me. I've got *me* covered, obviously."

His ears were still pinned back against his head. "Is it… disappointing?"

She smiled wide. "Oh, don't get me wrong. I've been pretty caught up with the idea of reunion sex for over a year now, and I've always wanted a chance to appreciate... the *rest* of you…" Hordak swallowed nervously. She bounced her eyebrows at him with a smoldering look before snorting and smiling simply again.

"...but I'm much more concerned with what *you* need. Like I said, I've got me covered. I want to make sure you're covered too, because- no offense- but you haven't been great about taking care of yourself since I've known you." He was blushing too hard to answer. "Now…" she broke off, suddenly looking much more uncomfortable. "I… I know you're not ready to talk about the time we were apart, but now…" she sighed. "If what you really want is a platonic relationship, I'm totally fine with that. I cannot stress that enough. I am happy with a platonic relationship with you." She paused until he met her eyes again briefly. "Buuut," she seemed worried, suddenly, "if you want… more… I want you to have that. Even if it's… difficult to navigate."

He swallowed drily again. "It's not that I don't want you… like that… anymore. I just… I'm having a hard time…" He took a deep breath and tried again. "I keep thinking of…" he couldn't even say the word *'him'* he was so pathetic. "I don't want what we do to be fouled by what happened," he said haltingly. "I couldn't bear it."

She leaned her head against his sharp shoulder, using her hair to cushion the harsh angle. "That's very reasonable."

"Are you sure?"

"Absolutely." She thought for a while, leaving her head on his shoulder. "Do you think you'll be able to separate what I do from what he did? Eventually?"

"I don't know, but…"

"But?"

"But… I still… want you."

She nodded and sighed. "Do you think… down the line, whenever you're ready… you might want to practice spending more time in your body instead of your head? No matter if that's just exercise or meditation or however you want to try."

He nodded, thinking hard. He trusted her implicitly, he wanted her to be proud of him, and he was so fucking tired of being bound by his past. As he struggled to dismiss the anxieties pulling at him from the shadows, he considered his options. He could stick with what was comfortable, take his time, and follow his instincts... but then again, he had never made a good decision in his entire life besides Entrapta, and following the draw toward her might be the only instinct he could trust. And, he reasoned, he'd been going on outlandish excursions out of his comfort zone for her since he'd met her anyway. "We could stop… if things started…?"

"Absolutely, without question," she assured seriously with furrowed brows.

When they'd first begun their affair in the Fright Zone, she'd approached it pragmatically, citing the direct correlation between increased workplace tension and decreased productivity. He'd known it was a flimsy excuse, but he was so damned curious and aroused he hadn't been able to help himself. She made him forget everything he'd ever believed and took him to an altered state of consciousness in a way no drug or drunk ever had.

The thing was, when he was in that state, he didn't have the capacity to hate himself. He didn't have the capacity for much of anything outside of giving and receiving physical pleasure. Hordak took a deep breath and she readjusted her head on his shoulder, waiting patiently.

He'd been angry. Mostly angry at himself, but also angry at her. He'd let her worm her way into his head, he'd allowed himself to be even further corrupted, and then it started distracting him while he worked. He couldn't remove her from the picture because she was getting him further in his mission faster than ever. The problem lay with him, and him alone. When she first coaxed him into her arms and the next few encounters after, he'd refused to let her manhandle him in the same way she'd done when she'd created his new armor. And yet, whether he'd admitted it to himself or not, he'd been hers from that point onward.

He'd maintained cool control of their activities at first, and hidden his terrified anxiety in his carefully curated persona. It helped to pretend he was still in control of his own life, but it was theater, and they both knew it. Once he'd gotten used to the idea of physical intimacy, she'd taken the lead in their relationship and it had been the most wonderful time in his life. He'd almost been happy.

On impulse, he turned his torso to her, where she sat at his side. He extended his hand and lifted her chin with his forefinger. "I…" he began without knowing how to continue. He settled on kissing her instead, pulling her easily into an embrace on his lap. When he felt her sigh contentedly in his arms, he impulsively lifted her up to straddle him, face to face in the dim light. Her hair was down and moving restlessly as if it were itching to wrap itself around him, and the feeling of her torso pressed up against his was a kind of carnal grounding. "I want to be here. With you."

Entrapta looked unsure. "Didn't you just have a really bad nightmare? Like, a minute ago?" she asked, scrunching her brow.

"Exactly," he insisted, "I don't want to think about it. I don't want to think at all." He kissed her again, trying to emphasize his sincerity with his desperate mouth.

She seemed torn. "Are you absolutely positive? I really, *really* don't want to push it."

Hordak hesitated for a moment, but looking up into her face, he knew he wanted her. He tried to reassure her with her own words. "I want to be in my body, not my head."

She gave in to her libido with a groan of relief, leaning against him shamelessly. A white-hot zing of roiling energy shot through his stomach and coiled in his lower abdomen, setting his pulse racing and sending intense heat through his entire body. As his skin burned and grew increasingly sensitive, she shifted on his lap, squeezing him around the middle with her legs. He continued their kiss and she let him lead the pace, taking things slow. "Let

yourself feel good," she whispered against his lips, "let me help, *please* ." He caught his first whiff of her arousal and his mouth started watering. He sighed into her kiss, furrowing his brow with concentration and nodding slightly.

Finally, after months and months, a low purr started in his chest. It was the first time he'd purred since their days together in the Fright Zone, and she wiggled in delight while he pulled his arms tighter around her. He swept his tongue lightly across the seam of her lips, which she opened for him eagerly, and she sighed luxuriously as he dipped his tongue into her mouth to taste her, once, then twice.

She leaned back into their kiss and engaged his tongue with her own, threading a hand into his hair. His breath caught and she stilled, pulling from his mouth gently. "Is this okay?" she asked in a soft voice.

He paused to think, doing his best to stay honest. "I, uh, I want it."

"You'll tell me if this gets too intense? Promise."

"I… it's good that… or, at least, I *think* I like that it's intense. You consume my attention entirely, Entrapta. You are a blessed refuge from the storm in my mind."

"I know what you mean!" she said, and there was an oddly triumphant note in her voice. Then a touch of color swept her cheeks. "I mean, you help me manage my brain, too. You've done more for me than you know."

He had a hard time with that claim, but he wasn't about to argue. "Anything for you, my princess," he whispered against her mouth, purr growing a little louder.

She kept whispering words of praise as she moved her torso against him languidly, and he felt himself harden beneath her, she groaned against him and rolled her hips with more pressure. When she breathed against the tender skin behind his ear he let

out an embarrassing trill, then moved his hand down to grip her ass in retaliation.

She ran her hands over his shoulders and chest, and he shivered when she pressed her palms into the meager muscle there. “How are you feeling?” she asked with a smile in her tone.

With his hands and ears and eyes full of Entrapta’s intoxicating presence, it was easier to ignore intrusive thoughts, though it was still more difficult for him to stay focused than it should have been. But now was not the time to examine this particular failure. “Like I’ve missed you with everything I am,” he growled.

She snorted softly and grinned, lifting a hand to stroke his ear. He trilled against the purring and blushed at his ridiculous noises, although they did seem to make Entrapta smile. “I want to make you feel good,” she whispered into the ear she was fondling. He caught a growl in his throat and pressed her down against his swelling cock, getting lost in her softness and warmth. “Tell me what you want, Hordak.” On her lips, even his name was beautiful. She glared up at him from under lavender lashes and smiled wickedly. “Or take what you want. Either way, I’m into it.”

What did he want? *What the fuck did he want* ? He took another deep breath and when he did, he was hit with a visceral, wonderful memory. “I want to taste your scent,” he murmured over the rumbling in his chest. The first time he’d ever said that to her, she’d nearly mauled him. It had a surprisingly similar effect this time as well. Entrapta gave a desperate whimper against his demanding mouth and rocked her hips against his, gripping at him with tightly clenching hands.

Hordak rolled them over, a little awkward in her narrow bed, so that he was braced on his knees and elbows over top of her. He tried not to hurry and tarried above her, soaking up her praise and attention. He settled into removing her clothes gently, peeling them back to reveal her glowing bronze skin inch by inch. Soon his purr was louder than ever as it poured from his open mouth, and he practically panted with desire.

He lowered his lips to her neck and began to plant openmouthed kisses down the fragrant skin there, breathing in her satisfied sigh and little noises of approval. As he moved down her body, he took a few moments to press openmouthed kisses to her soft breasts, but he was too caught up in his goal to linger. Before long he was kissing her belly in utter reverence, tasting her enthusiasm on the air and drinking in every luscious sound she made. But then she froze, which made him freeze, too.

"What is it?" he whispered, pricking up his ears to see if he could hear what had startled her.

"I totally forgot we're in a tent." He looked back up at her in alarm, thinking of the huge amount of people camping around them. "Hang on, let me handle the sound problem." With that, she was up and digging through her boxes, leaving him bereft and boiling as he watched her move. She was nude from the waist up by now, and it caught him by surprise when he noticed she'd already placed little pieces of machinery in a loose circle around her bed. With a wink, she clicked a tiny remote and a sparkling dome of some kind of dim pink energy lit up around them. He was still admiring her work when he felt her hands on his rumbling chest again.

"Impressive," he muttered at her as he stood and swept her into his arms. Then he laid her down gently on her back, and walked around to the foot of the bed. Her legs were pressed together as he grabbed her ankles and yanked her toward him, making her giggle. He sank to his knees, large enough to loom over her even as he did so, and slowed down to savor his actions as he lifted her legs, one at a time, to rest over his shoulders. He pressed a few firm kisses to her inner thighs just above her knees, enthralled by the impatient noises that escaped her.

His skin was hot, his hearts were pounding, and he was already growing dizzy as she overwhelmed his senses. While the sound field around them hummed lightly, Hordak settled into position, moving his mouth up the insides of her legs, licking and nipping her sweet skin between kisses.

Entrapta hummed and sighed, and rewarded him with lovely, breathy panting. He was panting too when he brought his face close to her sex, breathing her in deeply. He paused there to relish his miraculously good fortune, and the magnificent creature that deigned to return his love. When Entrapta tittered and squirmed, he delighted to realize his breath was tickling her. A chirp of glee left the back of his throat as he spread her open with two fingers, watching her slick glisten in the dim pink light. He saw a trickle of clear fluid run from her entrance, rolling down her body, and nearly drooled on her in anticipation. She gave a shaky whine and gripped the bedding tightly.

Hordak finally ran his tongue along her slit and groaned loudly at the exquisite delicacy that overwhelmed him. "Delicious," he moaned against her. He felt her legs shudder on his shoulders and his cock twitched eagerly. He licked her again, wetness spilling before the wide sweep of his tongue. Then he licked more deeply and slowly. For a moment he indulged in lightly circling her clit with the tip of his tongue, just to hear the beautiful sounds she gave him. Then he dove in eagerly, passionately, *desperately*, searching her taste out as an addict seeking a fix.

As he sipped her nectar, every sigh, gasp, moan and groan that fell from her lips went straight to his erection. "Oh wow," she gasped, and he looked up at her, meeting her eyes as he indulged. "Holy shit Hordak, I missed your *fucking tongue* ." She threaded the fingers of one bare hand into his hair and clutched at it lightly while he felt tendrils of her damp hair wrapping themselves around his limbs lightly, gently.

He rumbled a growl of approval and buried his face between her legs with renewed vigor, feasting on her sweetness and smiling through his moving mouth. As he switched his attention between different erogenous zones around her core and their pleasure rose, he felt himself melting deeper and deeper into the blurring feel of it all. Even her beautiful sounds seemed to fade in amongst the din of his swelling senses. He was panting, running one hand up and down one of her thighs while the other hand was gripping a hip. He watched her face in a daze, wide-eyed with wonder and

purring helplessly. Everything about her was utter perfection, she forged keys to the future in her miraculous work, and he would follow her to the ends of the universe. He would make sure they were never separated again. He simply *had* to.

He tried to pour these emotions into his task and reveled in the heady feeling it left him with. When he moved the hand from her hip to spread out over her stomach, he vaguely registered that he was pressing his deformed forearm against her bare skin. Before he could move it away, however, she grabbed his fingers with her free hand, clutching the ends of his digits tightly. He wrapped the rest of his hand around her fist, stroking the soft skin of her wrist with his thumb gently, losing himself in the slide of her skin on his wet cheeks and the warmth of her thighs against his ears.

From the change in the pitch of her moans and the small shudders rocking her frame, he knew she was going to come if he didn't pull back. But he was out of patience and eager to receive, so he drove her onward, mercilessly licking and suckling at her, pressing his face against her and growling deeply in tandem with has purring. He held her hips, grasping at the flesh there greedily as he pulled her body up against his mouth. Then, with one of her precious, small, breathless cries, she trembled through her climax, whimpering shakily. He drank in her release like he needed it to survive, riding out her shaking hips and spasming legs, lapping up every drop of essence he could.

When Entrapta pushed his head away, her whole body glistened with fresh dew as her panting slowed, eyes staring upward. “That was incredible. I fucking love you.” She tilted up his head so she could look down at him and he gave her a dripping, wolfish smirk. She whimpered, biting her lips, and they fell into a silence that started out as comfortable, but grew more intense as it stretched. “Are you okay?” she asked gently.

Hordak nodded, wiping his mouth on his mutated arm and trying to get a handle on his thoughts. He wasn’t sure exactly what he was feeling, other than very, very, *very* aroused. His cock was painfully hard at this point, but he was also nervous again and

worried. It was one thing to touch her, but to be touched? He wasn't sure if he was ready for that. She'd never seen him fully nude, and the clothing he wore now came off in one piece, so he'd have to open it down the front and expose his torso at the very least.

"Hordak?"

Her voice seemed loud against the quiet hum of her sound shield and he snapped his head back up to meet her gaze. "Yes," he said a little breathlessly. "I'm just not sure... I don't know what to do next."

"You don't have to. But I'd love it if you came up here next to me to think about it, instead of staying down there," she smiled at him, patting the bed beside her.

"Of course," he said, blushing. He brushed off his knees when he rose and came to lay beside her.

"You don't have to do anything you don't feel like doing, and you get to feel however it is you happen to feel. Don't forget that, Hordak."

He nodded softly and shifted his hips in discomfort as his erection caught awkward angles between his thighs and garment. Her gaze flickered downward, though he could tell by her expression that she was trying not to look at the conspicuous bulge at his groin. He felt his ears lower slowly as he looked at her, but then… *she licked her lips* , which struck him as incredibly unfair.

"Hordak," she brought his eyes back to hers, "It's okay if you don't want to do more tonight, regardless of the state of your weener." He smiled and the tension broke.

After another stretch of silence, he quietly ventured, "I do... I," He was nervous, but he definitely wanted her.

"What do you want, Hordak?"

"I want you, but…" She waited patiently while he figured out what to say. "I… I don't know." And he really *didn't* know- didn't know what to say, or what he needed, or how he wanted to move forward.

"Do you want to wait until you do?" Hordak shook his head and meant to reassure her, but still couldn't decide on what to say. But she didn't make him. Instead, she leaned forward and kissed him gently, stroking the side of his face with her small hand. "I'm big on verbal communication, but we don't have to talk about it if you don't want to. We don't even have to talk at all, even if you want to keep doing stuff. So long as you can tell me when I do something that's not working for you."

He looked up at her. Her suggestion seemed reasonable, and he nodded silently. This time when she pressed her lips gently against his, he deepened the kiss and reached out for her, fully relinquishing himself to the unknowable, swimming further into black waters in search of his siren.

He wanted both hands free and he rolled them over so that she was laying on top of him. He paused for a moment then, but she was small and light and he didn't feel trapped beneath her whatsoever. Now he almost laughed at the notion as he ran his hands over her naked body, luxuriating in the heat of her skin and listening to her sigh over him contentedly.

Entrapta seemed to understand he wasn't ready for forceful treatment, and she kept her touches feather light as she stroked his face and ears while they kissed. Her hair was drying much faster than he expected and he could see it growing more restless as their mouths moved against each other. She contained herself, though, and did not restrict his movement.

She was too short to grind directly against his erection while their mouths were still connected, but she lay her full length along his body and pressed a plush thigh against his cock. He growled, gripping her a little tighter, and she repressed a gleeful snicker. "Can I look at you?" she asked breathlessly as her fingers trailed

to the fastening of his undersuit. When his purr stopped and he tensed, her face flickered in contrition. “Agh, shit, sorry I forgot! You’re in the lead. You decide what you want.”

He bit his lip and summoned what confidence he could before nodding.

“That’s a yes? I can see all of you?” she asked, face brightening. When he nodded again she stifled a squeal. “Oh, Hordak, you don’t know how long I’ve wanted this.”

“Wanted what?” he asked in genuine confusion.

She smirked and lowered her eyelids to stare at him seductively. “Wanted to look at your body. All of it.” He gulped as she leaned forward and began to trail her fingers down his torso. “Every beautiful inch.”

He inhaled sharply at her shocking charity, but she soon covered his mouth with her own. She was getting more aggressive, but instead of getting nervous, he was losing himself in her bold presence. When she pressed her thigh against his hard length again, he heard himself let out an undignified whine into her mouth, and she offered a deep groan in return, clutching at his chest. Hordak dug his fingers through her hair against her scalp and pulled her face against his to deepen their kiss. Entrapta wanted him, and the very idea made him mad with lust.

This round, he made sure to take more time for her breasts. He brought his hands up to hold them, weigh and knead them. She moaned at the contact and his cock strained against his clothing. When he delicately twisted her hardened nipples between the pads of his fingers and thumbs, she started rubbing her leg firmly against his length, making him jerk and gasp. He wrapped an arm around the small of her back and pulled her forward so he could reach her breasts with his lips and tongue, kissing and licking the burning skin there before pulling one of her dark buds into his mouth. He looked up at her approving moan and met her eyes. Heat flooded his face as he sucked, and when he bit down lightly

he was rewarded with a whimper and the fluttering of her lavender lashes. He smiled against her supple flesh and felt her dig her fingertips through his hair.

Just then she seemed to remember that he'd given her permission to look at his entire body, and she jumped back to fumble with his suit. The purring stopped but he held still, willing himself not to upset her. When she'd found the hidden zip along the front seam, she looked up into his eyes and waited for him to reaffirm permission. When he nodded, short and tense, she bit her lip and began to undo the suit in agonizingly slow motion. She slipped fingers under the fabric as soon as there was enough room to do so, as if she couldn't wait for the zipper, running the flat of her palm over skin that had not yet known a gentle touch. She leaned up to kiss him through his shallow breathing and trailed her fingertips over the discolored and carved up skin of his chest, feeling along fat, angry self-surgery scars that were even uglier than the rest of him.

Entrapta kept her tug on the zipper steady, dragging it all the way down his body until his erection sprang free beneath her. He blushed at the undignified eagerness of his unworthy body, but she only seemed more excited. She moaned softly as she dragged her mouth away from his so as to start pressing kisses against his exposed chest, then she began to lift the fabric back toward his shoulders. He swallowed and willed himself to stay calm as she moved gently against him, kissing, nipping, stroking and petting. "Beautiful," he heard her murmur again, and he squeezed his eyes shut tight.

Entrapta adjusted the angle of her hand on his body and began to slide it down his stomach, stroking the contours of the muscle there as the flesh fluttered against her touch. His breath caught when she pressed her fingertips into the hollow inside of his hip bone. He resisted jerking his hips upward at the sensation, but he groaned through gritted teeth and she answered with her own decadent, sinful sounds.

Her touch was achingly slow as she trailed it from his hip toward his center, inch by agonizing inch, until she was finally able to cup his swollen cock against him. He growled savagely and thrust up against her, and she answered with a smug, breathy laugh. Renewed purring brought her free palm back up to the center of his chest to feel the vibration there and he covered her hand with his own, threading his other fingers back into her magic hair.

The soft hand on his erection began to press upward, then down, rubbing slightly in time with her own rolling hips. Her ragged breathing was turning into panting again as she pulled the hand from his chest to keep tugging at his clothing. He relented and helped her pull the garment away and off of his arms. She let out a moaning sigh while she dragged her gaze along his body, and his cock jumped beneath her. She bit her lip and suppressed an odd sound of glee as she cast another look up at him with glittering eyes. She would've been breathtaking, if she hadn't already stopped his breathing.

Her free hand ran all over his torso greedily, circling the sensitive skin around his ports and tracing his ribs before she returned it to hold his against his thrumming chest. He gasped raggedly when she finally wrapped her fingers around his shaft and gripped him firmly.

“Fuck, Entrapta,” he breathed as she drew the tip of his cock to her dripping entrance, swirling her thumb in the pre-come on it’s tip.

“I love you, Hordak,” she replied in a whisper, then began to sink down upon him. They both groaned and strained as she moved slowly, stretching herself gradually. She’d been unbelievably tight when they’d first had sex, and she was nearly as tight now. In the same instant he was both concerned that penetration might not be one of her proclivities when he wasn’t around, and wildly aroused that he might be the biggest thing she allowed inside of her body.

Entrapta started to move her hips again, rolling her entire body slowly above him. As graceful as she was, however, the bed they were on wasn't exactly sturdy. It shifted and swayed beneath them alarmingly and he gripped her thighs so that she'd pause long enough for him to breath and speak.

"I…" he panted, struggling to string a sentence together. "I think your camp bed… might be…"

She silenced him with a kiss before grinning down at him. "No problem," she smiled, and a sparkle of mischief filtered into her gaze.

Entrapta lifted herself from him and he groaned in protest when his length slipped out of her. Then she grabbed his upper arms and heaved him with her as she rolled to the side. Together they fell to the canvas floor, giggling like a couple of junior cadets. When she'd settled on top of him again, she began stroking his hair and face with both hands, leaning in and kissing him before backing up against his cock again. He reached between them, gripping his shaft and rubbing the swollen head up and down her dripping slit, making her gasp and twitch while he purred loudly through a slightly open mouth. He trilled through a whimper when she sank back down on him. He squeezed her hips harder than he should have and strained up into her, making her cry out through an open-mouthed smile.

Hordak used one arm to pull her tight against him and used his free hand to grip her backside, tilting her hips to give him a good angle as he bent his knees and drove home again. She cried out and he clamped his lips over hers to taste her passion. He broke the kiss to uncurl his body beneath her, focusing on his hips and hands instead. She kept moaning against his chest while he thrust up into her eagerly and surging energy filled him, fizzling in his skin and electrifying his breaths. She slipped one of her own hands between them so she could touch herself while he rolled his hips beneath her, stroking her own dripping folds.

A brand new thought struck Hordak when he realized he was smiling. Could this be it? One of those things people spent their whole lives chasing... something prime always promised but never gave... was this *joy* ? Real joy, untainted by sorrow or bitterness or desperation or doubt? Was he really a creature that might be *allowed to feel joy?*

The sight of her pleasuring herself and writhing on his cock broke the last of his control. With a hoarse shout, he wrapped both arms around her, clutching her close as he pounded into her. She cried out again, panting and writhing in his arms, hair wrapping around him tightly. When he moved a hand around behind her so that two long fingers slid down the sides of his own thrusting member to hold her swollen, flushed lips open, he felt her begin to shudder through another orgasm. He held her tightly so he could feel her shake and gasp. It took several moments for her to whimper through her spasming, her body gripping him in tight contractions. He let out one last broken cry through his own orgasm as her slick heat milked his cock, surge after surge.

When they were both fully spent, she lay down on him, hair limp, their damp bodies heaving with breathless pants. When she'd sufficiently collected herself, she moved off and upward so that she could nip his ear, which fluttered against her lips. "I love you," she whispered, voice full of rapture, "more than anything else in the universe."

He turned his head and pressed a kiss to her jaw. "Entrapta," he whispered against her, wrapping her in a gentle embrace, unsure of how to answer.

The sweetest, tenderest of smiles transformed her face into something altogether ethereal before she spoke again, and his hearts stuttered in his chest. "Hordak, I love you more than the stars."

Chapter End Notes

This time I can definitely remember reading the self- surgery thing in mazen's delightful work, so if you like that detail, go explore their other fun ideas.
If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

"We create our own futures, and we've decided on better."

Chapter Summary

> Just as the gang is settling in, a new crisis arises. Catra and Hordak will have to finish one more mission before they can face the future.

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was dark when the visitors left Entrapta's tent with easy smiles and began their trek back up to the palace, leaving Hordak and Entrapta to do… whatever the hell they did for fun. Probably math. Catra would guess math. She, for one, was glad to get away from Hordak. She didn't know why, but she didn't like seeing him so defeated. She found it perturbing and at this point, all she really wanted to do was curl up at the foot of Adora's bed and take a nap.

Eventually, the group of nine split into two smaller clusters as they went, with Frosta zooming off on her own, beating them to the palace by a wide margin. Perfuma, Swift Wind, Wrong Hordak, Netossa and Spinnerella formed the first group in their line, laughing and chatting together about the dinner they'd just shared. Scorpia hung back a little so that she could walk with Adora and Catra.

"Boy, I never would have believed it if I hadn't been there. Who'd have thought we'd ever hear the boss say something so nice?"

Scorpia chattered, jovial as ever.

“And that was?” Catra asked.

“You heard him, Wildcat,” Scorpia laughed, “He almost said he was proud!”

“That is absolutely not what he said,” Catra snickered. “He said we should be proud of ourselves.”

“To be fair, isn’t that the better option?” Adora asked. “I mean, it probably wouldn’t be a good thing if we were the type to make Hordak proud.” Catra snorted.

“I don’t knoooow,” Scorpia teased, grinning, “I think he might turn out to be okay after all.”

“That *was* pretty cute,” Adora conceded. At Catra’s rolled eyes, she started teasing. “Come on, Catra, I know you thought so too.”

“Did not,” Catra grumbled.

“Not broken, just built different?” Adora prompted, “C'mon, *come on* . That was cute.”

“Oh my gosh I know!” Scorpia said.

“Your face is cute,” Catra muttered to Adora. “And speaking of cute, it’s nice to see you with somebody who appreciates you, Scorpia,” Catra said with a guilty pang.

“Oh, well, geez.” Scorpia suddenly grew shy and rubbed her claw against the back of her head. She peered through the moonlit night, up the trail at Perfuma to make sure she wasn’t listening. But the group ahead was moving faster than they, and still talking animatedly. “I mean, we’re not even official or anything. I don’t even know if she likes me that much,” she said bashfully.

“Girl, Perfuma is fully obsessed with you. Lean in!” Adora said.

“Come on, Scorpia, you can’t deny she likes you,” Catra goaded.

“Eeeeeee! I know!” Scorpia squealed in delight, clacking her claws. “I can’t believe it!”

“Plus she’s crazy hot,” Catra added, earning an elbow from Adora.

“She’s soooooo pretty. And she likes tea! And feelings! Tea and feelings!” Scorpia gushed.

“So does Bow,” Adora said thoughtfully.

“Ugh, so does Kyle,” Catra said. She groaned, thinking about it. “We do *not* need a tea and feelings squad.”

“Too late!” Scorpia said, and Catra thought she might have heard a skip enter her step.

Catra was certain Scorpia was about to keep talking about Perfuma, but she was interrupted by a deafening, animal bellow that seemed to shake the ground they were walking on. Whatever it was, it was huge and it was extremely near.

“For the honor of grayskull!” Adora shouted without hesitation, transforming into She-Ra as the two separated groups moved nearer together. “Focus on keeping it away from the camp and buildings! It won’t hurt you unless you get between it and whatever it’s after!" Adora shouted, holding her sword out before her and backing toward the others. Catra nearly swore out loud. This new she-ra form was definitely hotter than ever, and she was pissed.

Catra held her claws out and ready and saw Wrong Hordak do the same after gently setting down the basket. She held her pose, knees bent, ears back, watching for the first sign of movement. She vaguely wondered where Entrapta and Hordak were. Surely they'd heard the roar.

For a few moments, everyone in front of the palace held still and silent, ready to fight whatever appeared. Then the woods right

next to them exploded as an absolutely gigantic elemental poured from the treeline and wound up before them.

“Fuck!” Catra shouted as the thing writhed and coiled. It was bigger than the palace entrance.

A huge, snakelike creature with far too many eyes reared up from it’s coil and regarded them for a moment. “Hold-” Adora houted, holding out a hand to keep the others from attacking.

Nobody else budged. Instead, they looked back up at the thing staring down at them with faintly glowing eyes, waiting for it to make the first move. A strange gulping sound started up, coming from the creature, and it’s body began to convulse rhythmically.

“What the…” Catra whispered. “Adora, wait,” she said as the other began to slowly approach the creature with her sword lowered.

“I think it’s sick or something,” She-Ra said slowly, coming to a halt just before the massive beast. It kept it’s many eyes on her as she approached, but it’s noisy convulsing grew louder. “It sounds kind of like you when you…”

The creature’s entire body heaved and it opened its mouth wide above She-Ra. “Adora!” Catra shouted, starting forward. But she was too late. The elemental gurgled as a large, slimy clump was forced up it’s throat, out its mouth, and dropped directly on top of She-Ra.

A blinding flash of light marked She’Ras un-transformation and when the brightness faded, the elemental had gone on it’s way and Adora was moaning at the stinking slime that coated her. “...spit up a hairball,” she finished miserably, looking up at Catra.

For her part, Catra would have pissed herself laughing at Adora, but the scene sobered as the other two beings in the gooey pile stirred. A pair of clones scrambled away from Adora hurriedly, hacking and sputtering and blinking in the light.

“Brothers!” Wrong Hordak cried joyfully. He raised his hands as if he’d won a game, but faltered when one of the clones wailed weakly before the other clapped their hand over his mouth, shaking his head and shushing him hurriedly. The clone with the covered mouth gave a feeble nod, tears streaming from his eyes over the other’s hand. “Brothers?” Wrong Hordak asked uncertainly. “Please do not fear. We are among friends here.” The two clones stared back at him in confusion. Catra was glad he still wore his whites for his brothers' sakes. Nobody dared move, lest they spook them. Even Adora kept still, drenched as she was in elemental hork.

After a few moments, the still-weeping clone pulled the other’s hand from his mouth gently. “Go,” he murmured through his tears. “Go with them.”

The other shook his head hard enough to make his ears flap, and began to cry himself. “No. No, we can fix this.”

“Go,” the first clone repeated. “We both know I’m done.” Now that he was speaking, Catra noticed that he was wilting, as if completely sapped of strength.

The other one kept shaking his head, straightening the others’ uniform compulsively.

“Excuse me,” Adora said gently from her place on the ground near them, “you two can stay together if that makes you more comfortable.” The clones looked at eachother with worried, watery eyes as Wrong Hordak nodded enthusiastically.

“Will…” the one who’d tried to silence the other began hesitantly, “will you help my brother? He can be of use again, he is very hardworking and professional. He could serve you well if you can make him better.”

“Of course,” Perfuma assured warmly.

“Is he hurt?” Adora asked. “I have healing powers, I can help if he’s injured.”

The clones looked into each others' eyes one more time before the weaker one lifted his uniform away to reveal a badly broken leg, bent at too many angles. Everyone in the group exclaimed and recoiled at the sight, and Catra heard Scorpia gag lightly. While Wrong Hordak and Perfuma moved to sooth the clones, Catra helped Adora up before she transformed back into She-Ra to heal the hurt one. She shone bright and clean, and Catra added another perk to her long list of reasons she should probably stop resenting She-Ra.

When She-Ra was finished and back to Adora again, she smiled warmly at the clones who were still huddled against each other on the ground. Catra could tell that she was drained, however, and came to stand close at her side. They looked up at her, confused and disoriented. "Is Horde Prime really gone?" One of them asked her.

She nodded and they broke down into renewed sobs. Catra grabbed Adora's hand and began to lead her away while she looked back over her shoulder at the group. "They'll be fine," she assured her gently, looking up at the stars as they climbed the stairs. "You need a shower and sleep."

* * * * *

After Entrapta had taken down her sound shield and they had both collected themselves and rearranged their clothing, they returned to bed. Emily came wandering back to her tent at some point, and Hordak untied the entrance flaps to let the bot in. As she questioned him about horde portal technology, Entrapta grabbed her communicator, which had received another new message while they'd been otherwise occupied. Her eyebrows quirked and he couldn't help himself. "What is it? What are you thinking?"

“Glimmer sent out a copy of the message you said we should send out to… you know, the other worlds in Prime’s empire. We worked on it just before we split for dinner and I think it’s actually pretty cute. Want to watch?” She leaned in toward him with the datapad before he even nodded.

They tilted their heads toward each other as her pad flickered slightly, then Glimmer and She-Ra appeared on screen. “Hey everybody,” Glimmer began awkwardly, clearly unused to being recorded. She-Ra too, looked uncomfortable, shifting side to side in her seat. He heard Catra snicker from off screen and She-Ra scowled. “So, we were thinking that, like, all the princesses could maybe appear together for the actual message. Um, so, I guess say what you think about that.” She and She-Ra cringed at each other slightly as the queen’s flow stalled.

“Uuuh but this is what we were thinking for the speech.” She-Ra took a turn. “That is, if you guys think a speech is the right move.”

“Right. Speech,” Glimmer seemed to be getting ahold of herself. “Speech mooode. Speeching... about to speech.” She cleared her throat and looked squarely at her audience. “My name is Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, commander of the Etherian Alliance, and this is She-Ra of Etheria. Yesterday, Prime tried to seize our magic, and Etheria defeated him. She-Ra destroyed him and the hivemind. His empire is broken.” She drew herself up and lifted her chin, slipping into a more queenly persona as she delivered her speech. Angella had taught her well.

“We are currently living in the dawn of a new age. Horde Prime is dead and gone. All those who have been oppressed in his empire are free. Etheria expresses our deepest sympathy to the rest of Prime’s victims, including his clones. We urge the rest of Prime’s previous empire to treat the newly freed clones with kindness and mercy, and give them the chance at life they’ve never had.”

Glimmer took a deep breath before continuing, and She-Ra stood still, looking directly at the audience. “Our destinies are now our

own. No more 'might makes right.' We realize now that we've come this far because we've had each other, so we're moving forward with each other in mind. Horde Prime lost because he didn't understand that people *are* more than random, meaningless nothings hurtling through an indifferent reality. We are more even than the universal laws of survival and power. We're magic. We create our own futures, and we've decided on better." She-Ra smiled and looked over at Glimmer, who smiled back.

"As Etheria moves forward, we endeavor to honor the truth, everybody's truth. We will seek and serve justice with compassion. Reconciliation will be achieved through responsibility, and together, we will endure with love and bravery, and build strength in friendship. Together, we will forge our future, and we will be free." Hordak let out a breath he didn't know he'd been holding as she came to her speech's end.

"You did great," She-Ra assured her, nudging her with her elbow.

"So, uh, yeah," Glimmer continued, dropping her official, dignified air. "I'll let you guys all think on that." The feed cut abruptly.

Entrapta looked over at him. "What did you think?" she asked.

He opened his mouth to respond, but closed it after a few silent moments. "I'm grateful to the queen for requesting mercy for my brothers," he eventually said.

"Glimmer is good, I think," she said in a comfortable, satisfied voice. She lay the data pad next to the his cuff on a crate nearby and snuggled back into bed, her hair nearly dry by this point.

It took a while for Hordak's thoughts to calm, but eventually he settled down, facing Entrapta on his side. Their breathing slowed in tandem and Entrapta slid a hand up his chest and neck so she could gently rub the tip of his ear between her fingers.

"What are we going to build first?" he asked quietly.

“We’ve got several projects to tackle,” Entrapta murmured, rubbing her thumb on the edge of his ear in hypnotic repetition. “We’ll need to focus on helping the princesses plan and carry out reconstruction, but we’ve also got another priority.”

“What’s that?”

“I think we might be able to get Queen Angella back.”

Hordak’s eyes snapped open, but Entrapta didn’t budge or stop moving her fingers. “Do you really think so?” he asked.

She giggled. “You and I have done crazier things. I think we have a real shot at it. Especially considering the whole immortal being thing and the fact that we now have access to Prime’s tech.”

“Hmmm,” Hordak hummed into her hair again and they lapsed into silence. He began to drift off and he could tell Entrapta was too by the slowing of her fingers on his ear. Emily powered down into sleep mode and the camp around them gradually fell quiet. Soon the only sound was the crackling of campfires and the occasional soft conversation between people in their tents.

A tinny, electronic shout rang out from his cuff, making them both jump so badly that the cot creaked loudly beneath them. “WHAT ARE YOU DOING?!” Princess Mermista’s voice demanded angrily.

Hordak flung his arm sideways and groped for the cuff. He brought it up above himself, doing his best to keep Entrapta’s hair out of sight but unwilling to remove his arm from beneath the crook of her neck. He fumbled the awkward device, however, and it smacked him in the face when it fell. Entrapta grabbed the screen from him, and he pinched the bridge of his nose with his free hand as she moved the cuff over above them, nullifying his attempt at discretion.

“Hi guys!” she exclaimed loudly. “We’re just chatting a little before sleep. Don’t worry, we’ll be productive soon. We’re just both…” she paused for a well-timed yawn, “too tired to work right now,” she finished.

Hordak watched Bow reposition their device to include more people in the image they could see. “No worries, Entrapta. We were just checking in to make sure you two were settling alright and didn’t need anything.”

“Oh no, we’re great,” Entrapta said happily as Hordak rubbed at his stumpy nose where the cuff had hit him. “Although, maybe take it easy on the surprise inspections until I can soup up Hordak’s pacemaker.”

“Ugh, fine,” Princess Mermista replied sullenly.

“Alright, well, rest up then,” Queen Glimmer said.

“See you tomorrow,” Adora added.

“Did we just see Hordak *cuddling* ?” asked a disgusted-sounding Mermista.

“Okay byyyee!” Entrapta said, waving before cutting the feed. She groaned and put it on her own side table before snuggling back up into Hordak’s body as he curled around her. “I know Mermista is still really upset, but she’s good too, I promise.”

“Actually,” Hordak mused, “something about her rather reminds me of Imp.”

“Oh! Imp!” Entrapta exclaimed loudly, reaching for her own data pad with her hair. “I forgot I asked Scorpia to check on that and…” she opened an unread message and cackled in triumph. “Bingo! I guess Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio have been taking care of him out in the Crimson Waste. They’re expecting our call.”

Waves of tingling energy swept his chest and he began to struggle upright, Entrapta shifting to help him before tapping into the communicator on her pad. Hordak held his breath as their call beeped once… twice… then a harried-looking young woman answered and smiled.

“Hi Lonnie!” Entrapta exclaimed.

“Hey Entrapta,” Lonnie said with a smile before her expression turned unsure. “Hello, Lord Hordak. Sir.” They could hear some kind of commotion was happening off screen.

“Just Hordak,” he corrected, offering what he hoped was an encouraging smile as he searched the background for signs of Imp.

“Right, I… hang on.” She pulled away from her device and shouted over her shoulder. “Guys! Shut up, it’s them!”

They heard a crash and a high-pitched shriek before the image jostled sharply. Imp had apparently snatched Lonnie’s device from her mid-flight and found somewhere high to perch. As his glowing eyes focused into view and the screen adjusted to the darkness, he chittered happily at Hordak, who smiled back and reached a few sharp fingers up toward the image instinctively.

“Still a domestic terrorist, I see,” Hordak murmured. “I missed you.” Somehow, he noticed, expressing such feelings toward Imp was easy, if embarrassing.

Imp chittered again and opened his mouth wider. “Missed you,” he replayed in Hordak’s voice.

“Hi Imp!” Entrapta said, “Emily’s here too! Say hi, Emily!”

Emily, who’d been woken up by the calls, beeped and whirred at them and was rewarded with another cheerful screech. The end of a broom handle appeared on the screen poking up haphazardly at Imp, who tucked in his extremities and ignored it. “Emily,” he replayed, “Missed you.”

The broom handle disappeared, but more off-screen discussion preceded a slim hand, stretching up toward Imp. “Almost… I can almost…” a young male voice strained before he cried out and they heard the sound of several people tumbling to the floor.

“Kyle!” Lonnie shouted as Imp shrieked at them with glee, “you okay?” she said more softly.

Hordak cleared his throat before speaking again. "I'm glad you're alright, little spy." He was unsure of what else to say. "I'm going to see you soon," he promised without yet knowing how.

"Soon… soon…" Hordak's voice echoed back at him as the image jostled and Imp took flight again. He apparently returned to the three ex-soldiers as Lonnie reappeared on-screen without further conflict. She set her device up against something and backed up so Hordak and Entrapta could see all three people. She stood to the side of a Lizard person, and on his other side was a slight young man holding the wiggling Imp. The Lizard person put his arms around the other two and squeezed them close, roaring a short sentence to them both.

"Thank you," Hordak replied. "I owe you an immense debt."

"Missed you," Imp replayed to him again before switching to the young man's voice. "I… I love you. I love you both so much."

"Awe," Entrapta said as all three people on screen blushed furiously. "We love you too, Imp!"

On that note, the tiny menace was apparently done with the conversation. He broke from the young man, who chased after him. Soon another crash made the other two cringe and the Lizard person walked off screen in the same direction.

"Alright," Lonnie said, still pink in the face, "I should probably go handle that, but uh…" she seemed reluctant to speak her mind. "Look, I normally wouldn't ask you any favors, but I don't suppose you've got a line on where ex-horde soldiers might be able to go? We escaped to the Crimson Waste and even though Rogelio is thriving, it hasn't been easy on Kyle. We've taken care of him so far, but he keeps getting into trouble with the locals and it's not going the best."

He and Entrapta looked at each other. "I know Scorpia's planning on taking in ex-horde, but Bright Moon is willing to temporarily

shelter them in return for labor…" Hordak began uncertainly, unwilling to make promises.

Entrapta nodded and smiled. "We're at Bright Moon. Can you guys travel here, or should we come and get you?"

Lonnie gave them a confused look. "Are you sure it's, you know, safe for us there?"

Entrapta snorted. "The princesses sentenced Hordak to community service after he suggested public execution, so my guess is you'll be fine. Plus, Hordak and I will look after you."

Lonnie's expression was outright alarmed. Then she scowled at them, and Hordak could tell she was trying to find any reason to distrust. Finally, she rolled her eyes and sighed. "Whatever. We've survived so far, how much worse can Bright Moon be than the Crimson Waste? We're out of here."

"Let us know what you need," Entrapta said cheerily.

"Uh huh," Lonnie said with open suspicion. "Anyway, it was good to see you Entrapta, and..." she hesitated, "Hordak. Uh, sir." He nodded as Imp shrieked in the background and Lonnie hurriedly cut the feed.

"That was soooo cuuuuute!" Entrapta crooned as she stretched next to him. "But I'm beat. Are you ready to get some sleep?"

Hordak only smiled wearily in reply as he lowered himself back down to a horizontal position. Entrapta commanded the lights off and nestled into the bedding across from him.

He meant to watch her fall asleep, but he was out before her breathing had evened.

* * * * *

He had more nightmares. Entrapta had to shake him awake again before dawn came, though she wasn't nearly as upset this time around. When he was shocked out of troubling dreams thereafter and he bobbed momentarily in semi consciousness before drifting off again, he was able to register her arms and hair wrapped securely around him.

It wasn't a good night's sleep by any stretch, but it was the best he'd had in many months. When Entrapta rose and began working, waking him gently, he even felt somewhat rested. He resisted the urge to groan at his stiff joints when he moved to get out of bed, slower than he would have liked. He got a little dizzy when he stood, but stayed on his feet as he shook his head lightly and ventured a few stretches.

"How are you doing?" Entrapta asked, peering up at him. "You look better."

"I feel better, thank you." He looked over at the shower again and hesitated. "I don't suppose… I know it's dreadfully frivolous, but…"

She turned around and smiled brightly. "Want to take another shower?"

He lowered his ears and looked away. "Very much so," he admitted begrudgingly.

"I snagged a few of your old things from the Fright Zone, though I haven't done anything about the Horde insignia on the dresses," a strand of pale purple hair pointed to a pile of clothing she'd put on a table nearby.

"Why did you fetch clothing while you were in the Fright Zone?" He cocked his head, genuinely bemused. She wasn't one to waste

packing space on anything other than tech.

"I was supposed to just be doing rebellion stuff, but I was also looking for signs of where you'd gone and," she gulped, "if you were still alive or not. I saw what you did to the Sanctum and I found your crystal, but no you and no Imp. I grabbed some clothes because I knew you'd hate the white once I got you back." He looked at her, taken aback, and she smiled tenderly at him. "I told you, I was *always* going to find you."

"Thank you," he said, crossing over to the clothes and marveling inwardly at her thoughtfulness. It was touching in the first place that anybody would do such a thing for him, it meant much more coming from somebody as focused and practical as Entrapta. He smiled when his hand hit terrycloth. "You even remembered the damned bathrobe," he said quietly.

"Yeah, well, when your partner is seven feet tall, you get used to accounting for size. I knew finding clothes big enough for you that weren't Horde issue might be tough, and I *know* you like that bathrobe, whether you'll admit it or not."

"Partner," he murmured.

She waggled her eyebrows at him. "Always." She seemed to consider something for a moment, hesitating to speak before making an apologetic face at him while he crossed to the tent entrance. "I may or may not have neglected to grab sleepwear while I was there. For, uh, selfish reasons."

He snorted and shook his head, smiling as he re-tied the tent flaps. Then he sobered, eying her as she turned around again. "Entrapta… I know there is much to do, but I worry that you're pushing yourself too hard."

"We'll take a vacation as soon as Etheria isn't in complete chaos, I promise."

"That doesn't address the issue at hand," he said, approaching her. "I know that you understand your own capabilities better than

I, but it would be wise to rest and avoid becoming… overwhelmed. Would it not?"

"You're right, but trust me," she fixed him with a stern glare, "I've got this. I've been through much worse before. As for getting overwhelmed," she scowled and his gut twisted at the needless shame in her expression. "I haven't had a meltdown in quite a while now, and I'm so much stronger than I used to be. I'm sure I'll be able to feel one coming on in time to stop it." He frowned, but didn't push her. She continued to chatter as he crossed to the shower and began to finally take his hated under-suit off for the last time. "And plus, I have so much to be excited for! I have you back, which makes me happy. I have a bunch of new projects, which is thrilling. Even science itself is throwing fun new variables at me now that She-Ra has unleashed the heart's magic."

He hesitated, not wanting to press her on such an intimate matter. "And… how about a routine? And time to slow down?"

"Well," this time she didn't have a ready answer. "It's kind of hard to maintain a routine when you're part of the last vestiges of a dwindling rebellion that's up against an intergalactic god. But! There's always tiny food!" She gave him a reassuring smile, but he could only nod at the strain he could see around her eyes.

She told him about the rest of the meeting he'd missed the day before, explaining that he and she would have access to their own ship because their technological expertise was in demand everywhere. Swift Wind, Wrong Hordak, Bow, She-Ra and George were heading up efforts with the clones and any Etherian refugees that needed help finding homes, either their own previous homes or new ones away from the bad memories. The labor and protection that the clones could provide would hopefully begin to bridge the gap between themselves, their previous civilian victims, and the strange new world they found themselves sharing. Glimmer would help the other princesses with relief distribution from headquarters at Bright Moon along with Micah's and Castaspella's help. Perfuma and Scorpia would return to Plumeria to make sure there was plenty of food to go around and get a

handle on her plant magic in their new environment and at new power levels. Once global hunger needs were being met, Scorpia and Catra would take on the Fright Zone, transitioning it from Hordak's military dictatorship back into Scorpia's kingdom. Entrapta would lead efforts in learning Prime's tech and readying Etheria for intergalactic communications and travels. He would assist her wherever and whenever she deemed necessary, but in the meantime he and Catra would lead the reconstruction of Salineas and the coastal settlements, which were still the most devastated regions in Etheria thanks to his final military campaign before Prime's invasion. They wouldn't be leaving for the sea kingdom until a few days later, which would give Entrapta some time to facilitate travel around Etheria first thing. Somehow, at the same time as all of this, they were also going to try and find a way to reach Queen Angella.

"Good news is that Micah told Glimmer about a cavern just near the castle that they'd once used for barracks before they decided it was too gloomy in there. I told her it would be perfect for us and it's isolated enough that she agreed to turn it into a proper lab! We'll have a real lab for when we're in Bright Moon! It should be ready to move into later today and I can finally put the finishing touches on your new suit!"

"You already made me a new suit?" He asked as he exited the shower in his bathrobe and toweled his hair.

She heaved an extended groan. "And now that I can reproduce Prime's fabric armor I'll have to come up with all new designs." She brightened. "In the meantime, I've been puttering away for ages. And I actually made two suits. One is a set of armor that I think you'll be very excited about. The one I made for domestic use is…" she failed to suppress a wicked grin as she looked at him sideways, "designed for comfort and versatility."

Her smirk filled him with trepidation. "Entrapta, what did you do?" he asked ominously, but before she could give him whatever cheeky answer was making her grin, they heard someone run into the tied tent flaps.

“Hey gu… wait what the…” It was Catra’s voice, and he heard her annoyed confusion as she struggled to find the opening. “Whatever,” she sighed before sliding a claw down the canvas of one of the flaps, creating a new entrance for herself. She waltzed in, closely followed by Melog, and tried again. “Hey guys. How’s it…” she stopped short when she spotted Hordak in the corner, indignantly clutching his robe shut tight at his throat. “Hordak, are you wearing a fuzzy bathrobe right now? Woah,” she said distractedly, eyes flicking down and one brow raising, “your feet are super weird.” Melog had the audacity to meow in apparent agreement.

He scowled instead of answering her and stomped across the tent as best he could, though he couldn’t put enough weight in his footfalls to really call it stomping. Melog wandered around the tent at a leisurely pace and eventually sat down to stare at Hordak serenely. He plucked a series of garments from the pile he’d folded and Entrapta mercifully broke in. “Hi Catra!” she said loudly and cheerfully, “Why are you here?”

“To say hello to your pretty face,” she replied smoothly, flashing a half smile. Hordak scowled at her again as he returned to the lab shower and frisked the canvas back in front of himself. “And his ugly one,” she added. “Heard you had a nightmare,” she said, raising her voice as if he’d left the tent.

“Already?” Entrapta asked in surprise.

“Soldiers and their gossip,” Hordak growled as he swapped his robe for a fresh dress.

“You know it,” Catra said with a lazy sigh. “Anyway I.. I uh…” Her voice turned awkward and Hordak puzzled as he pulled a stocking up his leg. “I guess I just wanted to say that I… I know what it’s like, uh, trying to bounce back from Prime. You’re…” she sucked in a breath, “not alone. On that. I don’t have any answers or anything, and I know that just because we deserve it doesn’t make it easier, um… and it hasn’t, you know, gotten easier. But…

yeah," she petered off lamely. Melog growled at her but she remained silent.

Hordak paused for a moment "Thank you, Catra," he said quietly. He took a deep breath of his own before pulling canvas aside and stepping from the shower to stand in front of Catra. He stood straight and folded the bathrobe over his bare forearms, hoping that she wouldn't notice that he was still wearing slippers instead of boots that were too cumbersome to manage without powered armor.

"Oh. Huh, compared to the red on your… dress, your eyes are already starting to look kind of orange. That was quick."

He had no idea what to do with Catra's inexplicable friendliness toward him, but before he could make things worse, Entrapta broke the awkward silence from where she was standing in front of several screens. "Aaah," she began, and Hordak could already tell something was wrong. "Hordak can you come look at this?"

He was at her side at an instant, studying what she was pointing at. He felt a sinking feeling in his chest and looked over at Entrapta, who gave him a worried look.

"Are you seeing what I'm seeing?" she asked. Melog mewled in concern

"All this wild magic around Etheria is… I'm not sure what's happening but the readings around her signature are dangerously destabilized."

"And getting worse," Entrapta confirmed. "We need to get her out, ASAP."

"Uh, is everything okay?" Catra asked.

"No," Hordak said. "And this problem directly concerns you."

"Of course it does," she sighed resignedly.

He ignored her words and fixed her with a stern glare. “We’re going to retrieve Queen Angella.”

Catra’s mouth fell open and she blinked in shock, but only for a few seconds. Then her face hardened, she set her jaw, and suddenly he was looking at the cunning, determined military leader he’d known in the Fright Zone. “What needs to happen?” she asked lowly, eyes alight and blazing.

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

End Notes

Lots of nods and references to other stuff and probably some borrowed shit throughout, just because I've soaked it up at some point and I either don't realize it or I don't remember where I got it. If you recognize what something comes form, then you remember more than I do and I encourage you to make mention of it in a comment or something. I’m not trying to be an asshole, promise. Also, if you think I should tag something that I didn’t, let me know. Cheers.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!